A GENTLE, PRACTICAL GUIDE

Your Mind Needs a Break

A Simple Guide to Overthinking, Stress, Anxiety and Finding Peace in Everyday Life



RATNESH RANVE

AN OPENPAGE BOOK

Your Mind Needs a Break

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Important note. This book is intended for general education and everyday emotional well-being. It does not diagnose, treat or replace the care of a qualified doctor, psychologist, psychiatrist or counsellor. Everyone's situation is different. If your distress is severe, persistent or getting worse, or if you are thinking about harming yourself, please seek professional help immediately. In an emergency in India, call 112. For free, 24-hour mental health support, call Tele-MANAS on 14416.

The people and situations described in this book are invented examples created for illustration. Any resemblance to real people is coincidental. Helpline details were checked in October 2026 and may change; please verify them on official websites.

Illustrations: original artwork created for this book.

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A Note Before You Begin

Dear reader,

If you picked up this book, there is a good chance your mind has been busy for a long time.

Maybe it is busy at night, when the house is quiet and the thoughts get louder. Maybe it is busy in the morning, before you have even opened your eyes properly. Maybe it is busy in the middle of an ordinary day, while you are sitting in class, in a meeting, on a bus, or at the dinner table, nodding along while a second conversation runs inside your head.

I want to say something simple first: there is nothing shameful about this.

A busy mind is not a broken mind. Most of the time, it is a mind that is trying very hard to keep you safe, prepared, liked and successful. It is doing too much of a good thing. It has forgotten how to put the work down.

This book will not ask you to “just relax” or “stop thinking so much”. If that worked, you would have done it already. Instead, we will go slowly. We will look at what actually happens in an overthinking mind, why it feels so hard to switch off, and what small, practical things can help.

You will not find big promises here. You will not become a perfectly calm person by the last page, and you do not need to. The aim is gentler and more useful than that: to help you notice your thoughts a little earlier, respond to them a little more kindly, and take one helpful action more often than before.

Read slowly. Skip around if you need to. Come back on hard days.

Your mind has been working very hard. It is allowed to take a break.

How to Use This Book

You do not have to read it in order. Part One explains what overthinking and stress feel like. Parts Two and Three look at the specific worries that keep people stuck: the future, failure, comparison, other people's opinions, the body, sleep, relationships, money and family. Part Four gives you practical tools. Part Five brings everything together into a seven-day plan and explains when to seek more support.

Each chapter follows the same shape, so you always know where to find things:

- **An opening moment.** A small scene you might recognise.
- **What is happening.** A plain-English explanation, without jargon.
- **A moment of understanding.** A short pause to remind you that you are not alone.
- **Practical steps.** Specific things to try, with examples and what to do if they do not help straight away.
- **A short exercise.** Usually between two and ten minutes.
- **Before and after.** A realistic example of what a small change can look like.
- **One small step for today.** One action, one question, one line to carry with you.

Keep a notebook or notes app nearby. Many exercises ask you to write a few lines. Writing helps because it moves a thought out of your head and onto a page, where it is easier to look at.

Use the worksheets. At the back of the book you will find ten printable worksheets. You can print them, copy them into a notebook, or fill them in on a tablet.

Go at your own pace. If one idea helps, stay with it for a week before trying the next one. One habit you actually use is worth more than ten you only read about.

If something does not suit you, skip it. Not every tool works for every person. Some people love breathing exercises; others find them uncomfortable. Some people find writing helpful; others prefer talking. This book gives you options, not rules.

An important note. This book is for education and everyday support. It is not a diagnosis and not a replacement for a doctor, psychologist, psychiatrist or counsellor. If your distress is strong, lasting, or making daily life hard to manage, please read Chapter 18 and reach out for professional support. If you are in immediate danger or thinking of harming yourself, call **112** now, or the free Tele-MANAS helpline on **14416**.

Where Should You Begin?

Find the line that sounds most like you, and start there. You can read the rest of the book in any order.

My mind will not switch off, especially at night.	**Ch. 1 + Ch. 9** p. 10, p. 69
I keep replaying conversations, messages and “what ifs”.	**Ch. 2 + Ch. 12** p. 18, p. 89
Small tasks feel heavy and I do not know where to start.	**Ch. 3 + Ch. 15** p. 26, p. 108
I worry about my future: exams, placements, jobs or money.	**Ch. 4 + Ch. 11** p. 34, p. 81
I am afraid of failing or not being good enough.	**Ch. 5** p. 41
I keep comparing my life with other people’s.	**Ch. 6** p. 48
I find it hard to say no, or I worry what people think of me.	**Ch. 7** p. 55
I feel stress in my body: tension, headaches, restlessness.	**Ch. 8** p. 62
I find it hard to fall asleep or stay asleep.	**Ch. 9** p. 69
I overthink my relationships or assume what others are feeling.	**Ch. 10** p. 75
Money, career or family expectations are weighing on me.	**Ch. 11** p. 81
I feel overwhelmed in the moment and need to calm down now.	**Ch. 13** p. 95
I cannot make decisions, or I keep reopening them.	**Ch. 14** p. 102
I had a bad day and feel I am back to square one.	**Ch. 16** p. 113
I want a simple plan to get started this week.	**Ch. 17** p. 120
I have felt this way for weeks, it is getting worse, or I am not safe. Please read Chapter 18 now. In an emergency, call 112, or call Tele-MANAS on 14416 (free, 24×7).	**Ch. 18** p. 125

PART ONE

Understanding What You Feel

Why the mind will not switch off, why small things feel heavy, and what may be happening underneath.

01

CHAPTER 1

Why Does My Mind Never Switch Off?

It is 11:40 at night. The lights are off. Your phone is face down on the bed, finally.

You close your eyes. Your body is tired. You have been waiting all day to lie down.

And then your mind switches on.

Did I reply to that email? I should have said something different in the meeting. The electricity bill is due on Friday. What if the report is not good enough? Why did my friend sound so short on the phone? I need to wake up at six. It is already 11:52. If I do not sleep now, tomorrow will be terrible.

You turn to the other side. You check the time again. 12:15.

Nothing is wrong in the room. Nobody is asking you anything. But inside, it feels like a crowded railway platform at rush hour.



Every unfinished thought is like an open tab. At night, the mind clicks through them one by one.

What you might be experiencing

Many people describe the same feeling in different words. “My brain does not have an off button.” “I am tired, but I cannot rest.” “Even when I am free, I do not feel free.”

In daily life, it can look like this:

- You lie down to sleep and start reviewing the whole day.
- You sit with family or friends, but part of your attention is somewhere else.
- You try to watch a film to relax, but you keep picking up your phone.
- You finish one task and immediately feel the weight of five others.
- You wake up and, before you even get out of bed, the list has already started.

This is often called **mental overload**. In simple words, it means your mind is holding more open questions than it can comfortably carry at one time.

It can be triggered by big things, like exams, a new job, a health worry at home or money problems. But it can also build slowly from many small things: unanswered messages, half-finished tasks, a comment someone made, a decision you keep postponing.

Similar experiences can have different causes. For some people it is mostly stress and a busy season of life. For others, it may be connected to long-standing worry, low mood, sleep problems, or something that needs a doctor's attention. This book will not try to label you. It will help you understand the pattern and try some practical steps. If the feeling is strong or lasts for weeks, Chapter 18 explains how to find more support.

What may be happening in your mind

Think about the browser on your phone or laptop.

Every time you start something and do not finish it, it is a bit like opening a new tab. "Reply to Ananya" is a tab. "Pay the fee" is a tab. "What did my manager mean?" is a tab. "Am I on the right career path?" is a very heavy tab that never closes.

During the day, you are busy, so the tabs stay in the background. At night, when there is nothing else to look at, your mind starts clicking through them, one after another. Many of them are not even urgent. They are just open.

Your mind does this for a reason. It is trying to make sure nothing important is forgotten. It is like a helpful assistant who keeps reminding you of everything, all the time, without understanding that 11:40 p.m. is not the time to plan next month's budget.

Thoughts that feel unfinished also tend to come back. When a worry has no clear next step, the mind keeps returning to it, hoping that this time it will find the answer. Often it does not. It simply goes around again.

The hidden cost

A mind that rarely switches off can quietly take a lot from you.

- **Energy.** You may feel exhausted even on days when you have not done much physically. Thinking all day is tiring work.
- **Attention.** It becomes harder to concentrate, because part of your mind is always somewhere else.
- **Rest.** Free time does not feel restful. Sleep may come late or feel light.
- **Enjoyment.** Good moments pass by without being fully felt.
- **Patience.** Small things may irritate you more than usual, because your mind is already full.

None of this means something terrible will happen. It simply means your mind needs a different way to carry its load.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

You are not lazy because you feel tired after a day of "doing nothing". A day of constant thinking is not a day of nothing. Your mind has been running in the background like an app you forgot to close. It makes sense that you are drained. You do not have to earn your rest by solving everything first.

What can help

Step 1: Do a "brain dump" once a day

What: Write down every open tab in your mind, without sorting or judging.

How: Take a page or a notes app. Set a timer for five minutes. Write everything that is on your mind, big or small: "Call the bank. Mehul's birthday. Fear of failing the exam. Fix the tap." Keep writing until the timer ends.

When: Early evening works well for many people, before the night thoughts begin. Some prefer the morning.

Example: Priya, a second-year engineering student, writes fourteen items one evening. Seeing them on paper, she realises only three are for this week.

If it does not help immediately: That is normal. The relief often comes later, when a thought returns and you can tell yourself, "It is already written down."

Step 2: Sort the list into three groups

What: Separate what you can act on from what you cannot.

How: Next to each item, write one letter. **A** for "I can do something small about this in the next two days". **L** for "Later; it needs time, information or another person". **W** for "This is a worry I cannot act on right now".

When: Right after the brain dump. It takes two or three minutes.

Example: "Pay the fee" gets an A. "Choose a specialisation" gets an L. "What if I never find a good job?" gets a W.

If it does not help immediately: Do not aim for perfect sorting. A rough sort is enough to show your mind that not every item needs attention tonight.

Step 3: Close one small tab

What: Finish one tiny task from your A list.

How: Pick the smallest one, something that takes under ten minutes. Send the message. Pay the bill. Put the form in your bag.

When: As soon as possible after sorting, or first thing the next day.

Example: Rahul has been meaning to reply to his cousin for a week. It takes three minutes. That tab stops opening at midnight.

If it does not help immediately: Closing one tab will not empty your mind, and it does not need to. It shows your brain that open loops can be closed, which makes the next one easier.

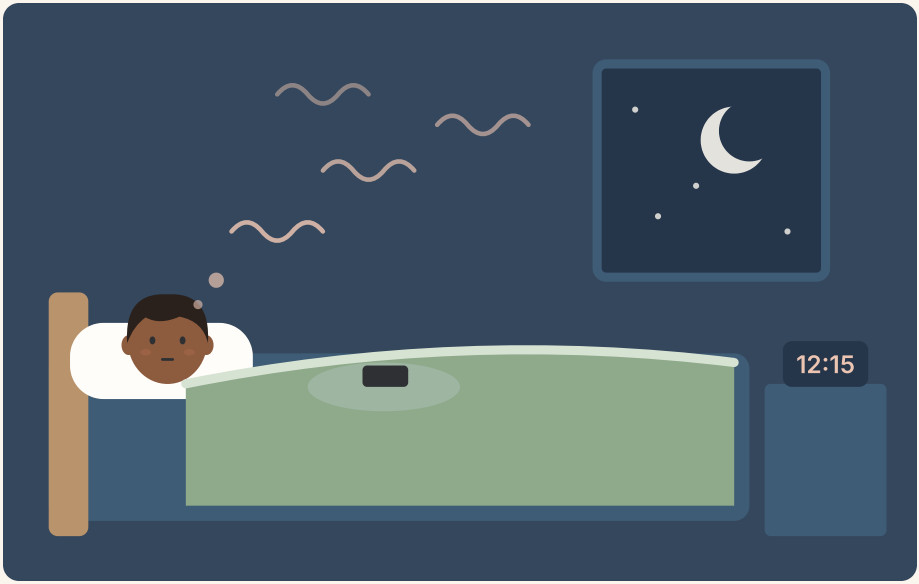
Step 4: Give the "later" items a home

What: Put each L item somewhere you trust: a calendar, a reminder, a list you check every week.

How: Write the item with a day attached. "Saturday morning: look at specialisation options for 30 minutes."

When: Once a day, at the end of the brain dump.

If it does not help immediately: Your mind may keep reminding you anyway for a few days. It is learning to trust the new system. Each time, gently say, "It is on Saturday's list."



Nothing is wrong in the room, but the mind is wide awake.

Exercise: The Five-Minute Brain Dump

Time: about 7 minutes

1. Set a timer for five minutes.
2. Write every thought, task, worry and reminder that is on your mind. Do not stop to fix spelling or put things in order.
3. When the timer ends, read the list once.
4. Mark each item **A** (act soon), **L** (later) or **W** (worry I cannot act on right now).
5. Circle one A item you can finish today.
6. Write one sentence at the bottom: *"Everything else is on this page. I do not have to hold it in my head tonight."*

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Arjun, 27, works in sales in Pune. Every night he lies awake listing tasks in his head. He gets up twice to check his phone for emails, and then feels annoyed at himself for not sleeping.

After two weeks of trying the brain dump: Arjun still has busy nights. But most evenings at 9 p.m. he spends five minutes writing his list. When a work thought comes in bed, he reminds himself, "It is on the list." Some nights he still falls asleep late. But he stops getting up to check emails, and the nights feel a little less crowded.

One small step for today: Before you sleep tonight, write down five things that are on your mind. Just five.

Reflection question: Which open tab has been in your mind the longest, and what is the very first tiny step towards closing it?

A thought on paper weighs less than a thought in your head.

02

CHAPTER 2

Overthinking Everything

> You sent a message to a friend at 2:10 in the afternoon. A simple one: *"Free this weekend?"*
>
> At 2:14 it shows as seen. No reply.
>
> At 3:00 you check again. Still nothing.
>
> By 4:30, your mind has written a whole story. *Maybe she is upset about what I said last week. Maybe I was too direct. Maybe she only meets me because she feels she has to. Maybe the whole group talks without me.*
>
> You open the chat and read your old messages, looking for clues. You type a second message, delete it, type it again, delete it again.
>
> At 7:15 she replies: *"Sorry yaar, crazy day at work! Sunday works?"*
>
> You feel relief. And then, quietly, you feel tired. You spent five hours inside a story that was not true.

What you might be experiencing

Overthinking is not the same as thinking carefully. Careful thinking moves towards an answer or a decision. Overthinking goes around in circles.

It often shows up as:

- **Replaying conversations.** Going over what you said, how you said it, and what the other person's face looked like.

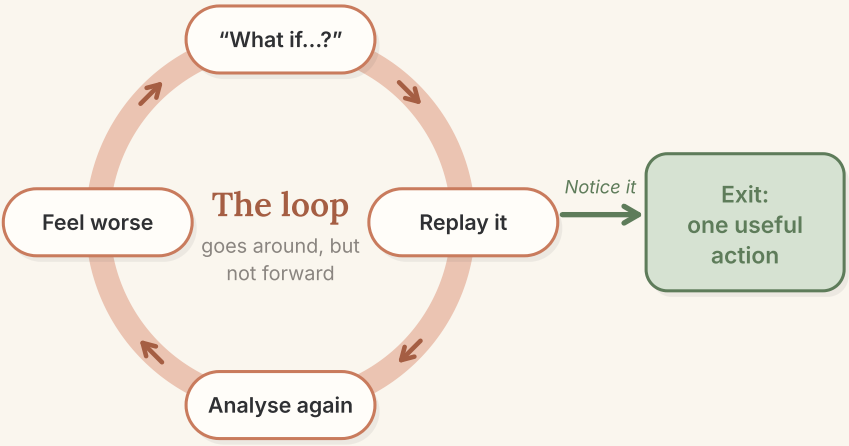
- **Analysing messages.** Reading meaning into a short reply, a late reply, a missing emoji or a full stop.
- **Imagining the worst.** Jumping from a small event to a big disaster in a few steps.
- **"What if" chains.** What if I fail? What if they find out? What if I choose wrong?
- **Indecision.** Collecting more and more information, and still not feeling ready to choose.

It is very common, and it can show up in anyone: toppers and those who barely passed, managers and new joiners, parents and teenagers. It often grows when you care a lot about something, such as a relationship, an exam, a job or how others see you.

What may be happening in your mind

Your mind is a problem-solving machine. That is one of its greatest strengths. When something feels uncertain, it starts searching for an answer, the way your phone keeps searching for a network when the signal is weak.

The trouble is that many of the questions we overthink **do not have answers available right now**. You cannot know exactly what your friend was feeling. You cannot know your exam result before the exam. So the mind keeps searching, finds nothing solid, and starts again.



Overthinking goes around the same path. Noticing the loop is the first step towards the exit.

Each time you go around the loop, the worry can feel a little more important, simply because you have spent so much time on it. It is like walking the same path through grass many times: soon it becomes a clear track, and your feet go there automatically.

Overthinking can also feel *useful*. It can feel like preparation, or like protection: "If I think about every possibility, I will not be surprised." Sometimes a little of that is helpful. But past a certain point, extra thinking stops adding safety and only adds tiredness.

The hidden cost

When overthinking becomes a habit, it can:

- Take hours out of your day without you noticing.
- Make simple decisions feel heavy.
- Affect your sleep, appetite or concentration.

- Create distance in relationships, because you are reacting to the story in your head instead of the person in front of you.
- Reduce your confidence, because you start believing your mind's worst guesses.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

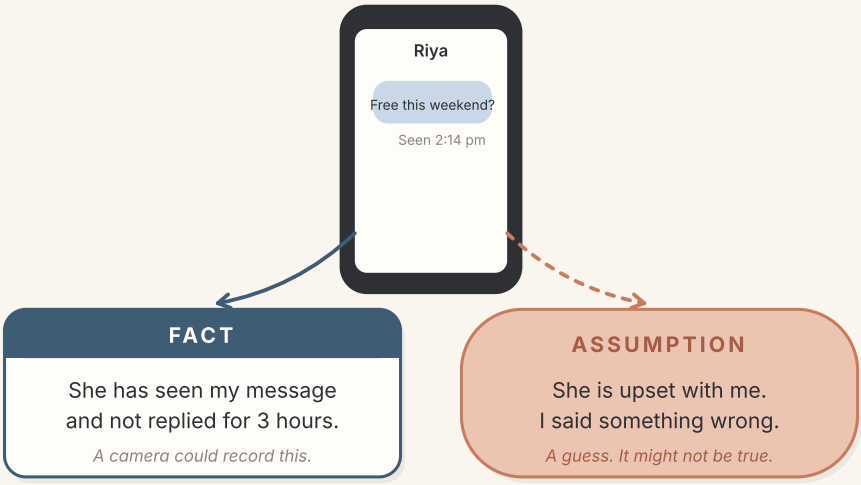
If you overthink, it usually means you care. You care about doing things well and about the people in your life. That is not a flaw. The goal is not to stop caring. It is to stop paying for your care with so much of your peace.

The most useful question: fact or assumption?

One of the simplest tools for overthinking is to separate **what you know** from **what you are guessing**.

A **fact** is something you could show to another person. "She has not replied for three hours." A camera could record that.

An **assumption** is your mind's explanation. "She is angry with me." Nobody can see that. It might be true, but it might not be.



A fact is what a camera could record. An assumption is the story the mind adds.

Overthinking often mixes these two together until the guess feels as real as the fact. Pulling them apart slows the story down.

What can help

Step 1: Notice the loop and name it

What: Catch yourself in the act of going around again.

How: When you notice you are replaying the same thing, say quietly to yourself, “I am in the loop again.” You can even give it a name: “the message loop”, “the exam loop”.

When: Any time you realise you have been thinking about the same thing for more than a few minutes without getting anywhere.

Example: Sneha notices she has read her boss’s email four times. She says, “Okay, this is the email loop.”

If it does not help immediately: Naming a loop does not switch it off. It just helps you take half a step back from it. That small space is where choice begins.

Step 2: Write facts and assumptions in two columns

What: Separate what happened from what you are imagining.

How: Draw a line down the middle of a page. On the left, write only what a camera could record. On the right, write what your mind is guessing.

When: When a situation keeps pulling you back, especially about people or results.

Example: Left: "My manager said 'let's discuss the report tomorrow'." Right: "She hated it. I am going to be criticised. Maybe I will lose this project."

If it does not help immediately: You may still believe the assumptions for a while. That is fine. Just seeing them labelled as guesses often lowers their volume a little.

Step 3: Ask, "Is there a useful next action?"

What: Check if the thought is pointing to something you can do.

How: Ask: "Is there one action that would actually help here?" If yes, do it or schedule it. If no, the thinking is probably not helping right now.

When: After you have separated facts from assumptions.

Example: For the report, a useful action is to re-read it once tonight and note two points to explain tomorrow. Re-reading it twenty times is not useful.

If it does not help immediately: Sometimes there is no action, and that is uncomfortable. Move to Step 4.

Step 4: Set a "worry appointment"

What: Give your worries a fixed time instead of letting them follow you all day.

How: Choose 15 minutes at the same time each day, not near bedtime. When a worry comes at another time, note one word and tell yourself, "Not now. At 6 o'clock." Then think it through on paper.

When: Try it daily for at least a week. Researchers have studied this "worry postponement" idea for decades, and many people find it useful, though it does not work the same way for everyone.

Example: Imran sets his worry time at 6:30 p.m., after he gets home. By then, some of his daytime worries no longer feel important.

If it does not help immediately: Postponing is a skill. In the first few days, you may forget, or the worries may push back. Each time you postpone one worry, even for ten minutes, you are practising.

Exercise: Fact or Story?

Time: about 5 minutes

1. Write the situation you keep thinking about in one sentence.
2. Draw two columns: **Facts (what a camera could record)** and **Stories (what my mind is adding)**.
3. Fill in at least three items in each column.
4. Look at the Stories column. Next to each one, write one other possible explanation. *(For example: "She is angry" → "She is busy at work.")*
5. Ask: "Is there one useful action?" Write it down, or write "No action needed right now."

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: After a group presentation in college, Kabir replays one moment where he forgot a line. He thinks about it for the rest of the day, sure everyone noticed and now sees him as weak.

After: The next time, Kabir notices, “I am in the presentation loop.” He writes: *Fact:* “I paused for about five seconds and then continued.” *Story:* “Everyone thinks I am stupid.” He writes an alternative: “Most people were thinking about their own part.” He still feels a bit embarrassed, but he returns to his evening instead of spending it inside the memory.

One small step for today: The next time you notice a loop, write down one fact and one assumption about it. Just one of each.

Reflection question: Which loop visits you most often, and what name would you give it?

Your mind is allowed to ask “what if”. You are allowed not to answer every time.

03

CHAPTER 3

When Small Things Feel Too Heavy

It is Sunday afternoon. You have a few free hours.

You need to finish your project file, call the gas agency, buy a birthday gift, reply to the society WhatsApp group, clean your room, and start preparing for Tuesday's test.

None of these things are huge. Any one of them would be fine.

But together they feel like a wall.

So you sit on the bed with your phone. You open Instagram "for two minutes". Forty minutes later, nothing is done, and now you also feel guilty.



Each responsibility is a small stone. Carried together, they get heavy.

What you might be experiencing

Sometimes the problem is not one big crisis. It is the pile.

Small responsibilities collect, one on top of another, until even simple tasks feel heavy. You might notice:

- Feeling overwhelmed by ordinary things, like replying to a message or making a phone call.
- Not knowing where to start, so you do not start.
- Switching between tasks without finishing any.
- Doing easy, unimportant things to avoid the important ones.
- Feeling irritated or close to tears over something small, like a missing charger.

This is sometimes called **mental load**: the invisible work of remembering, planning and keeping track of everything. It is often carried by people who manage households, look after family members,

or are the “responsible one” at work or among friends. It does not show from the outside, but it is real work.

What may be happening in your mind

Imagine carrying a bag. Each responsibility is a small stone. One stone is light. But when you keep adding stones without ever taking any out, the bag becomes heavy, and the next stone, however small, feels like too much.

That is why the “small thing” that upsets you is often not really about that thing. It is about everything that was already in the bag.

There is another reason ordinary tasks can feel huge. When a task is **vague**, the mind sees it as one big, shapeless block. “Clean the room” or “prepare for the test” has no clear first step. The mind does not know how to begin, so it feels uncomfortable, and we turn to something easier. This is not laziness. It is the natural response to a task that has no handle.

The hidden cost

When this pattern continues, you might:

- Spend more energy *worrying* about tasks than *doing* them.
- Feel constantly behind, even when you are working hard.
- Lose time to avoidance, then feel guilty, then avoid again.
- Become short-tempered with people you love.
- Stop doing things that refresh you, because “there is no time”.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Feeling overwhelmed by small things does not mean you are weak or incapable. It usually means you have been carrying many things for a long time, often without anyone noticing. The heaviness is real, even if each task looks small to someone else.

What can help

Step 1: Empty the bag onto the table

What: Write every task down so you can see the full load.

How: Use the brain dump from Chapter 1. List everything, including the "small" things.

When: When you feel the wall building, and ideally once a week.

If it does not help immediately: Seeing the full list can feel worse for a moment. That is normal. You cannot sort what you cannot see.

Step 2: Pick only three for today

What: Choose what matters most, and give yourself permission to leave the rest.

How: From the list, circle three tasks: one that is urgent, one that is important, and one that is small and quick.

When: At the start of the day, or the evening before.

Example: Urgent: call the gas agency. Important: one hour on the project file. Quick: reply to the society group.

If it does not help immediately: If three still feels like too much, choose one. A finished small task is better than an unfinished big plan.

Step 3: Break the big task into tiny steps

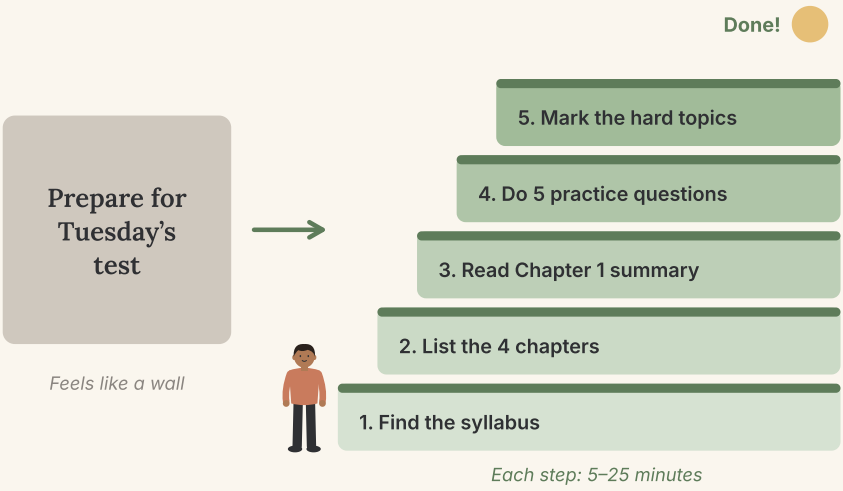
What: Turn a shapeless task into a staircase.

How: Ask, "What is the very first physical action?" Write steps so small they almost feel silly. Each step should take between 5 and 25 minutes.

When: Whenever a task feels heavy or you keep avoiding it.

Example: "Prepare for Tuesday's test" becomes: (1) Find the syllabus. (2) List the four chapters. (3) Read the summary of Chapter 1. (4) Do five practice questions. (5) Mark the topics I find difficult.

If it does not help immediately: If even the first step feels hard, make it smaller: “Open the notebook” counts.



A task that feels like a wall becomes manageable when it is turned into small steps.

Step 4: Use a short timer

What: Work in short, clear blocks with a break after each one.

How: Set a timer for 20 or 25 minutes. Work on one step only. When it rings, take a 5-minute break: stand up, drink water, look out of a window.

When: For any task you have been avoiding.

Example: Meera tells herself, “I only have to do 20 minutes of the project.” Often she continues after the timer. Sometimes she does not, and that is still 20 minutes more than before.

If it does not help immediately: Some days your focus will be low. Reduce the timer to 10 minutes. Starting is the hardest part.

Step 5: Take one stone out of the bag

What: Remove, delay or share one task.

How: Look at your list and ask: "Does this really have to be done by me, and by this week?" Some things can be delegated, delayed or dropped.

Example: "I will ask my brother to collect the parcel." "The cupboard can wait until next month."

If it does not help immediately: Asking for help can feel uncomfortable, especially if you are used to doing everything. Start with something small and low-risk.

Exercise: Build a Staircase

Time: about 8 minutes

1. Write one task you have been avoiding at the top of a page.
2. Ask, "What is the very first physical action?" Write it as Step 1.
3. Keep going until you have 4–7 steps. Each should take no more than 25 minutes.
4. Next to Step 1, write *when* you will do it: today at a specific time.
5. Do Step 1. Then tick it off.
6. Notice how you feel after one tick. Write one word.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Lakshmi, a working mother in Chennai, has wanted to sort out her son's school documents for three weeks. Every time she thinks of it, she feels tired and puts it off.

After: She writes the steps: find the folder, list what is missing, call the school office, print two forms. On Saturday morning she does only the first two steps in fifteen minutes. The task is not finished, but it has a shape now, and the rest happens over the next two days.

One small step for today: Choose one task you have been avoiding. Write only its first step, and do that step.

Reflection question: What is one "stone" in your bag that you could share, delay or drop this week?

You do not have to climb the whole staircase today. You only have to find the first step.

PART TWO

The Thoughts That Keep You Stuck

The future, failure, comparison, and other people's opinions.

04

CHAPTER 4

Fear of the Future

You are on the metro on your way to college. Your earphones are in, but no music is playing.

Placements start in two months. Your friend already has an internship offer. Your parents asked again last night, gently but clearly, “What is the plan?”

You look out of the window and your mind runs ahead. *What if I do not get placed? What if I get a job I hate? What if I have to move to another city alone? What if I choose wrong and waste years? What if everyone else is settled and I am still figuring things out at thirty?*

By the time you reach your station, you have lived five possible futures. None of them have happened yet. All of them have made you tired.



The mind often travels ahead into five possible futures before we reach our stop.

What you might be experiencing

Worry about the future is one of the most common forms of overthinking. It might be about:

- Exams, results, admissions or placements.
- Jobs, promotions, layoffs or changing careers.
- Money: savings, loans, rent, EMIs, supporting family.
- Marriage, relationships or where you will live.
- The health and future of the people you love.

These are real concerns. The future *does* matter, and some planning *is* needed. The difficulty comes when your mind keeps visiting the future without bringing back anything useful, only fear.

What may be happening in your mind

Your mind dislikes uncertainty. When it cannot see what is coming, it tries to fill in the blanks. Unfortunately, it often fills them with the most frightening option, because that is the one it most wants to protect you from.

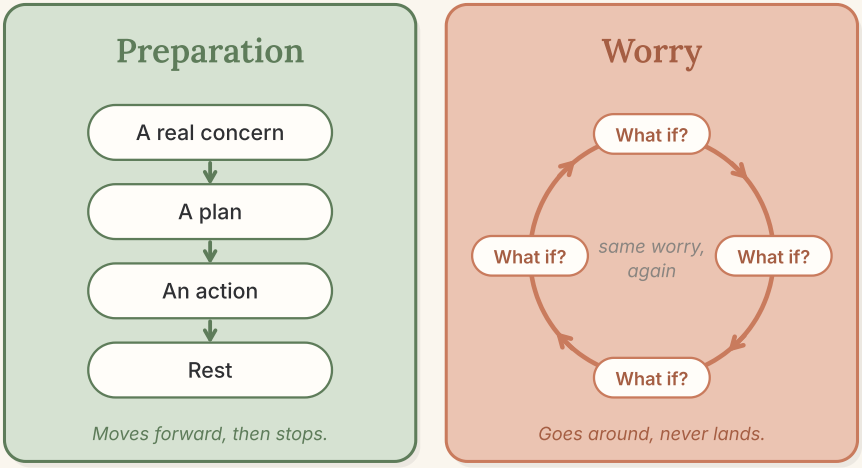
Think of a smoke alarm. Its job is to warn you about fire. A good alarm is sensitive. But a very sensitive alarm can go off when you are just making toast. The alarm is not broken; it is doing its job a little too eagerly. Future worry can work similarly. It is your mind's warning system reacting to "not knowing" as if it were danger.

Preparation and worry are different

This is the most important idea in this chapter.

Preparation looks at a real possibility and asks, "What can I do about it?" It leads to an action, and then it rests.

Worry looks at a possibility and asks, "What if it happens?" again and again. It does not lead to action. It just repeats.



Preparation moves forward and then rests. Worry goes around without landing.

For example:

- *Preparation:* "Placements are in two months. I will update my resume this week and take two practice aptitude tests every weekend."
- *Worry:* "What if I do not get placed? What if everyone gets placed except me? What if...?"

Both start with the same concern. Only one of them moves you forward.

The hidden cost

Living in the future can:

- Take your attention away from the present, where the actual work happens.
- Make you feel like you are failing at something that has not even happened.
- Lead to rushed decisions just to end the discomfort of not knowing.
- Or the opposite: freeze you so that you avoid preparing at all, because looking at the future feels too frightening.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Nobody knows exactly how their life will turn out, not your parents, not your seniors, not the people who look most confident online. Feeling unsure about the future is not a sign that you are behind. It is a sign that you are human, standing at the edge of something you cannot fully see yet.

What can help

Step 1: Turn "what if" into "if... then"

What: Finish the sentence your worry leaves unfinished.

How: Write the "what if" and then add a calm "then" plan. "If I do not get placed in the first round, then I will apply off-campus, ask two seniors for referrals, and take a short course to strengthen my profile."

When: When the same future worry keeps returning.

If it does not help immediately: Your plan does not need to be perfect. Just knowing you have *a* response lowers the feeling of helplessness for many people.

Step 2: Ask, "What can I do in the next seven days?"

What: Bring the future down to a size you can act on.

How: Write the big worry. Then write two or three actions you can take in the next week, even very small ones.

Example: Worry: "I will never save enough money." Next seven days: "Write down this month's expenses. Find one subscription I do not use. Read one simple guide on budgeting."

If it does not help immediately: Some worries have no seven-day action. Use Step 3 for those.

Step 3: Practise "I do not know yet"

What: Allow uncertainty to exist without arguing with it.

How: When your mind asks a question about the future that cannot be answered today, reply gently: "I do not know yet. I will know more when it gets closer." Then bring your attention to one thing in front of you: the station board, your breathing, the page in your hand.

When: On the metro, before sleep, during long waits, whenever the future pulls at you.

If it does not help immediately: The mind may push back: "But I need to know!" That is normal. Repeat the sentence calmly. You are training a muscle that has rarely been used.

Step 4: Collect information, then stop

What: Do your research, but set a limit.

How: Decide in advance how much information you need. “I will read about three career options and talk to one person in each field.” Then make a decision or rest the question until a set date.

When: For big decisions about studies, jobs or money.

If it does not help immediately: You may want to keep searching “just to be sure”. More information often does not bring more certainty. See Chapter 14 for more on decisions.

Exercise: The Preparation Plan

Time: about 10 minutes

1. Write your future worry as a “what if” sentence.
2. Rate how likely it feels from 0 to 10, and how likely it really is, based on facts, from 0 to 10.
3. Write: “If this happens, then I will...” and list two or three responses.
4. Write: “In the next seven days, I can...” and list one or two small actions.
5. Write: “The parts I cannot control right now are...”
6. End with: “I have prepared what I can. The rest, I will meet when it comes.”

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Rohan, 24, preparing for a government exam in Lucknow, spends hours each night imagining failing and disappointing his family. His study hours shrink because he is so tired from worrying.

After: He writes his “if... then” plan: if he does not clear this attempt, he will take one more attempt while doing a part-time job, and discuss a backup career with a cousin who works in a related field. The fear does not disappear. But when it comes at night, he tells himself, “I have a plan for that.” He uses his mornings for study instead of recovering from the night.

One small step for today: Take one future worry and write one “if... then” sentence about it.

Reflection question: Which part of your future worry can you prepare for, and which part do you need to leave to time?

You cannot walk on a road that does not exist yet. You can only take the next step on the one in front of you.

05

CHAPTER 5

The Fear of Failure and Not Being Good Enough

> The presentation is due tomorrow. It is already good. You have checked it three times.
>
> But you open it again.
>
> You change the font. Then you change it back. You rewrite the second slide. You worry that the conclusion is weak. You imagine your team lead's face, slightly disappointed. You imagine your colleague's work looking much better than yours.
>
> It is 1 a.m. The presentation is now 4% better and you are 60% more tired.
>
> Somewhere in your mind, a quiet voice says: *If this is not perfect, they will see that I am not good enough.*

What you might be experiencing

Fear of failure can take many forms:

- **Perfectionism:** feeling that work is never finished, never good enough.
- **Procrastination:** delaying something because you are afraid of doing it badly.
- **Self-doubt:** feeling you got where you are by luck, and soon others will find out.
- **Fear of judgement:** worrying about what teachers, bosses, relatives or friends will think.

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** “If I do not come first, I have failed.” “If I make one mistake, the whole thing is ruined.”

In many Indian homes and classrooms, marks, ranks and results are discussed openly and often. Many families do this with love and hope. But a child who grows up hearing “what about the other 5 marks?” can become an adult who sees every task as a test of their worth.

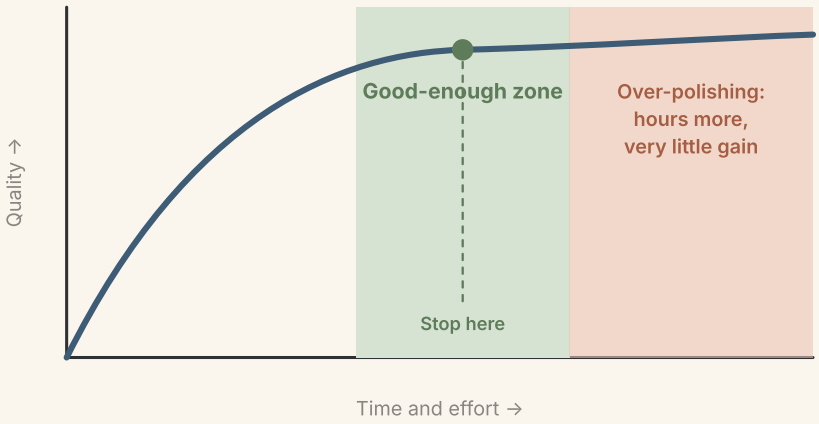
What may be happening in your mind

At some point, many of us learn a rule without realising it: **“I am acceptable when I perform well.”**

This rule is powerful. It pushes people to work hard, and often brings real success. But it has a hidden side. If your worth depends on your results, then every task becomes risky. A small mistake no longer feels like “I made an error”. It feels like “I am not good enough”.

So the mind tries to protect you in two opposite ways. Sometimes it pushes you to *over-prepare*, checking and polishing endlessly. Other times it makes you *avoid*, because if you never really try, you can never really fail.

Both are forms of protection. Both are exhausting.



After a point, extra hours add very little. The good-enough zone is where you can stop.

The hidden cost

Over time, the fear of failure can:

- Make you spend three hours on work that needed one.
- Stop you from applying, speaking up or trying new things.
- Make success feel like relief instead of happiness: “Phew, I did not fail.”
- Make criticism feel like an attack, even when it is helpful.
- Leave you tired and still feeling behind.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

You are more than your marks, your salary, your designation and your last performance review. These things matter, but they are things you do. They are not who you are. You were worth caring for before you ever achieved anything, and you still are, on days when things go badly.

What can help

Step 1: Define "good enough" before you start

What: Decide the finish line in advance, so you know when to stop.

How: Before a task, write two or three things it needs to do. "The presentation needs to explain the three results clearly and fit in ten minutes." When those are done, the task is done.

When: For any task where you tend to over-polish: assignments, reports, messages, even social media posts.

If it does not help immediately: You may feel uncomfortable stopping. Notice the discomfort, and stop anyway. The discomfort usually fades faster than you expect.

Step 2: Talk to yourself as you would to a friend

What: Notice the harsh voice and answer it more kindly.

How: When you think, "I am so stupid, I always mess up," ask: "What would I say to a close friend who said this about themselves?" Write that answer down, and read it to yourself.

When: After a mistake, a bad result or criticism.

Example: Instead of "I failed the mock test, I am useless," Tanvi writes: "This mock test went badly. It shows me which chapters to revise. One test does not decide my whole future."

If it does not help immediately: Kindness to yourself may feel fake or even uncomfortable at first. Research on self-compassion suggests it is a skill that can be learned and strengthened. It usually gets easier with practice.

Step 3: Separate the mistake from yourself

What: Describe what happened, not who you are.

How: Replace “I am a failure” with “This attempt did not go the way I wanted.” Replace “I am careless” with “I missed a detail. Next time I will check it.”

When: Whenever you notice “I am…” sentences after a setback.

If it does not help immediately: Old habits of speaking to yourself are strong. You only need to catch one sentence a day to start.

Step 4: Try a small, safe “imperfect” experiment

What: Deliberately do something at “good enough” and see what happens.

How: Choose a low-risk task: an email, a short note, a casual drawing. Do it in a fixed time and send it without the extra checking. Then notice the result.

Example: Siddharth, a junior analyst, sends an internal update after one read instead of five. Nobody notices any difference. He gains forty minutes.

If it does not help immediately: You may feel anxious after sending it. That anxiety is your old rule being tested. Let it pass without going back to check.

Step 5: Count effort and learning, not only results

What: Give yourself credit for what you control.

How: At the end of the day, write: one thing I tried, one thing I learned, one thing I did even though I felt unsure.

When: Every evening for a week.

If it does not help immediately: It may feel unimportant compared to marks or targets. Keep going. You are teaching your mind that effort counts.

Exercise: A Letter From a Kind Friend

Time: about 10 minutes

1. Think of a recent mistake or failure that still bothers you.
2. Imagine a close friend went through exactly the same thing and told you about it.
3. Write a short letter to that friend. What would you say? How would you say it?
4. Now read the letter again, this time as if it were written to you.
5. Underline one sentence you most need to hear. Write it on a sticky note or save it in your phone.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Divya, 29, a teacher in Kolkata, has avoided applying for a senior role for two years. She tells herself she is “not ready yet”. Every time a post opens, she imagines being rejected in front of her colleagues.

After: She defines “good enough” for her application: a clear resume and one page about her teaching approach. She asks a friend to read it once, and submits it. She does not get the role this time. It hurts, and she allows herself to feel that. But she also notices that she survived the “no”, and she now knows what the interview panel looks for.

One small step for today: Choose one task and write down what “good enough” looks like before you start.

Reflection question: Whose voice does your inner critic sound like, and is it still a voice you want to follow?

Done with care is better than perfect and never finished.

06

CHAPTER 6

Why Do I Keep Comparing My Life to Others?

> You open Instagram while waiting for your tea.
>
> A college friend has just bought a car. Someone from school is engaged, with photos from a beautiful hill station. A former colleague has moved to Canada. Someone younger than you has started a business. A cousin has posted a “small celebration” for her promotion.
>
> You close the app. Your tea is now cold.
>
> Nothing bad happened to you in those five minutes. But you feel smaller, slower and somehow behind, as if everyone else got a map to life and you were never given one.

What you might be experiencing

Comparison is natural. Humans have always looked around to see how they are doing. But today we compare ourselves with hundreds of people, every day, through a screen.

You might notice comparison around:

- **Career:** who got placed, who got promoted, who earns more.
- **Money:** houses, cars, holidays, gadgets.
- **Milestones:** marriage, children, buying a home, “settling down”.
- **Appearance:** bodies, skin, clothes, filters.
- **Achievements:** marks, ranks, certificates, followers.

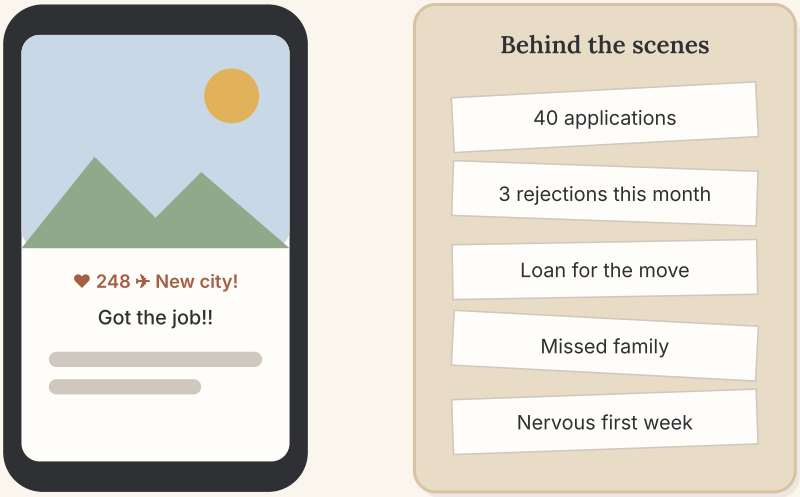
You might also hear comparison from people around you: “Sharma ji’s son got into IIT.” “Your friend is already married.” These are often meant as encouragement, but they can feel like a measurement you keep failing.

What may be happening in your mind

When you scroll, you see other people’s **highlights**. You see the wedding photos, not the arguments before the wedding. You see the job announcement, not the forty rejections before it. You see the holiday, not the loan that paid for it.

Meanwhile, you see your own **behind-the-scenes**: your doubts, your bad days, your bank balance, your messy room.

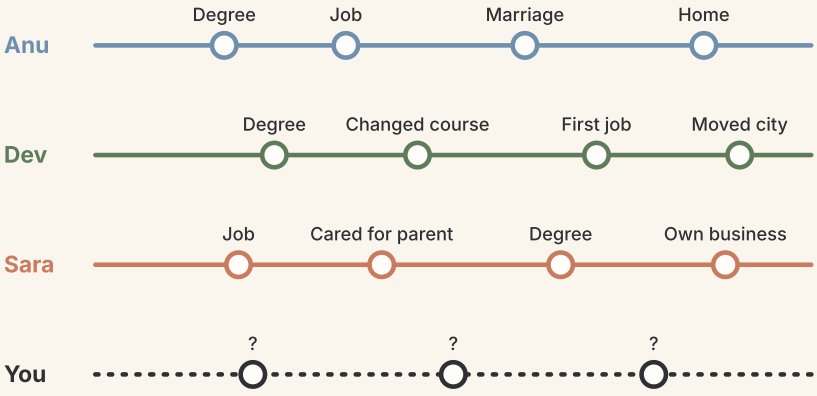
So the comparison is not fair. It is your full, unedited life against everyone else’s best moments.



We compare our full story with other people's highlights.

There is also a second problem: the idea that there is **one correct timeline**. Degree by 21, job by 22, marriage by 27, house by 32. But real lives do not follow one schedule. People study later, change careers,

move cities, take care of family, recover from illness, start again. Being “behind” someone else’s timeline does not mean you are behind on your own.



Different paths. Different speeds. No single correct timeline.

There is no single correct timeline. Each life has its own pace.

The hidden cost

Unhelpful comparison can:

- Turn other people’s good news into your bad feelings.
- Make you dissatisfied with things that were enough yesterday.
- Push you towards goals you do not even want, just because others have them.
- Strain friendships, because envy is uncomfortable to sit with.
- Steal time and attention from your own path.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Feeling envious or left behind does not make you a bad person. It often points to something you care about: security, love, recognition, freedom. The feeling is information. You do not have to act on it by criticising yourself.

What can help

You do not have to delete every app. The aim is to use them more consciously, so they do not use you.

Step 1: Notice how you feel after scrolling

What: Become aware of your patterns.

How: For three days, after you close a social media app, write one word about how you feel: *calm, inspired, low, jealous, bored, connected*.

When: Every time, or at least a few times a day.

If it does not help immediately: Just noticing is the first step. You are collecting information, not judging yourself.

Step 2: Tidy your feed

What: Reduce content that regularly makes you feel worse.

How: Use the “mute”, “unfollow” or “not interested” options for accounts that often leave you feeling small. You do not need to unfriend anyone. Muting is private. Add a few accounts that teach you something, make you laugh or calm you down.

When: Set aside ten minutes for this during the coming week.

If it does not help immediately: Feeds take time to change. Keep using “not interested” on content that drains you.

Step 3: Set gentle limits, not total bans

What: Choose when you scroll, instead of letting it happen automatically.

How: Pick one or two “no-scroll” times, such as the first 30 minutes after waking and the last 30 minutes before sleep. Or move social apps off your home screen so opening them is a choice.

If it does not help immediately: You may reach for the phone out of habit. That is fine. Notice it, put it down, and try again.

Step 4: Turn envy into information

What: Ask what the comparison is telling you about your own wishes.

How: When you feel envious, ask: “What exactly do I want here? Is it the thing itself, or what it represents?” Then ask, “Is there one small step I can take towards that, in my own way?”

Example: Seeing a friend’s travel photos, Aditya realises he does not want the expensive trip. He wants a break. He plans a weekend at his grandmother’s village.

If it does not help immediately: Sometimes the answer is “I want this, and I cannot have it right now.” That is painful, and it is okay to feel sad about it.

Step 5: Compare with your past self

What: Measure your progress against where you were, not where others are.

How: Write: “One year ago, I could not… Now I can…” Include small things: cooking a meal, handling a difficult call, saying no once.

When: Once a month, or on a day you feel behind.

Exercise: My Own Timeline

Time: about 8 minutes

1. Draw a line across a page. Mark your birth at the left and today at the right.
2. Mark five to eight moments that mattered to you: things you learned, survived, built or chose.
3. Include difficult times you came through, not only achievements.
4. Look at the line. Write one sentence starting with: “My life has its own pace, and…”
5. Draw a small dotted line beyond today. Write one thing you would like to add to it, in your own time.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Fatima, 31, feels a heavy sadness every time a school friend posts about her children or new home. She scrolls late at night and then lies awake comparing.

After: She mutes a few accounts, keeps her phone outside the bedroom, and makes her own timeline. She realises she has built a career she is proud of and supported her younger sister through college. Some posts still sting. But the sting lasts minutes now, not the whole evening.

One small step for today: After the next time you scroll, write one word for how you feel.

Reflection question: Whose timeline have you been measuring yourself against, and is it really yours?

You are not late for your own life.

07

CHAPTER 7

When Other People's Opinions Control Your Peace

> Your colleague asks if you can "quickly" help with her slides. You already have two deadlines today.
>
> "Sure, no problem!" you say, smiling.
>
> Later, a relative calls and asks you to arrange something for a family function. You agree before you have even thought about it.
>
> That night you finish your own work at midnight. You feel tired and a little resentful, and then guilty for feeling resentful.
>
> In bed, you replay a moment from lunch. *Did they think my joke was weird? Was my tone too much? Do they actually like me?*

What you might be experiencing

When other people's opinions hold a lot of power over your peace, you might notice:

- **Difficulty saying no:** even when you want to or need to.
- **People-pleasing:** putting others' comfort before your own needs, again and again.
- **Fear of rejection:** worrying that if you disappoint someone, they will leave or think badly of you.
- **Overanalysing:** replaying how you came across in a meeting, a party or a group chat.
- **Changing yourself:** adjusting to fit what you think each person wants.

In many cultures, including many Indian families and workplaces, respect, harmony and adjusting to others are deeply valued. These are good values. But when they turn into never having a say, they can become a heavy burden.

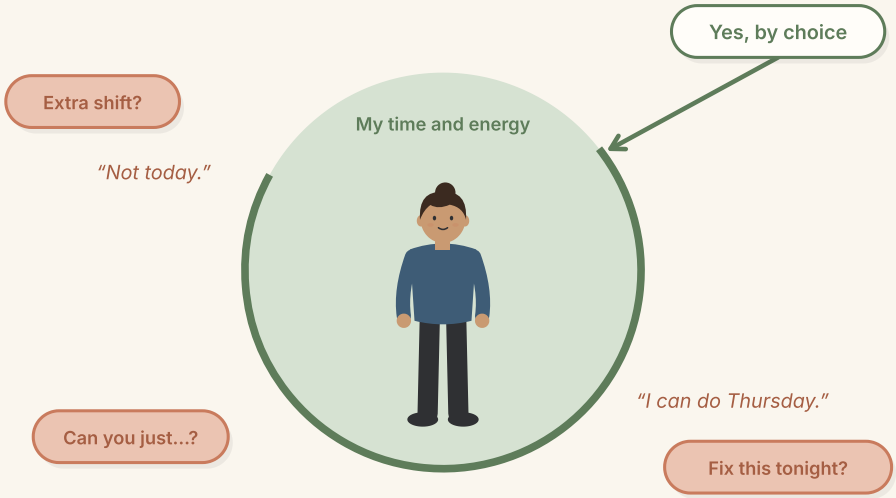
What may be happening in your mind

Humans are social beings. For most of our history, being accepted by the group really did matter for survival. So the mind is very sensitive to signs of disapproval: a frown, a silence, a short reply.

For some people, this sensitivity is turned up high. They may have grown up in homes where keeping others happy kept things peaceful, or where love felt like it depended on being "good". So the mind learned: *If they are happy with me, I am safe.*

The difficulty is that you cannot control what everyone thinks. And when your peace depends on everyone's approval, it is always at risk.

Think of your energy and time as a house. Boundaries are the doors. A house with no doors is open to everyone, all the time. A house with locked doors keeps everyone out. A healthy house has doors you can open and close, by choice.



A boundary is a door you can open by choice, not a wall.

The hidden cost

Living for others' approval can lead to:

- Exhaustion from doing too much for too many people.
- Quiet resentment that builds over time.
- Losing touch with what *you* actually want or feel.
- Relationships that feel one-sided.
- Anxiety in social situations, followed by hours of replaying.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Wanting to be liked is not weak or silly. It is deeply human. But you deserve relationships where your needs also count. Saying no to a request is not the same as rejecting a person. People who truly care about you can handle hearing "I cannot do this right now."

What can help

Step 1: Pause before you say yes

What: Create a small gap between a request and your answer.

How: Use a "pause sentence":

- "Let me check my schedule and get back to you in an hour."
- "Can I think about it and reply tonight?"
- "I need to see what else I have this week first."

When: Any time you feel the automatic "yes" rising.

If it does not help immediately: You may still say yes out of habit. That is okay. Just notice it. Next time, try the pause.

Step 2: Use simple, kind boundary scripts

What: Say no or set a limit clearly, without long explanations.

How: Choose a script that fits your style:

- **Simple no:** "I am not able to do that this time."
- **No with care:** "I really want to help, but I cannot take this on today."
- **Partial yes:** "I cannot do the full slides, but I can look at the first three for ten minutes."
- **Delayed yes:** "I can help on Thursday, not today."
- **With family:** "I love being part of this. I can handle the sweets order, but I cannot manage the decorations this time."
- **At work:** "If I take this on, the client report will be delayed. Which one should I prioritise?"

When: Start with low-risk situations, such as small favours with colleagues or friends.

If it does not help immediately: The other person might be surprised or a little disappointed at first. That does not mean you did something wrong. Disappointment is a normal feeling, and they can handle it.

Step 3: Notice the "mind-reading"

What: Catch yourself assuming what others think.

How: When you think, "They must think I am boring," ask: "What do I actually know? What else could be true?" Use the facts-and-assumptions columns from Chapter 2.

When: After social situations you tend to replay.

If it does not help immediately: It may help to remember that most people are busy thinking about how *they* came across.

Step 4: Check in with your own needs

What: Remember that your needs are part of the equation.

How: Before agreeing to something, ask: "What do I need right now? Rest? Time? Space? Help?" Your answer does not always win, but it deserves to be heard.

When: Daily, even for one minute.

Exercise: Practise One Boundary

Time: about 6 minutes

1. Think of one situation where you often say yes when you want to say no.
2. Write what usually happens and how you feel afterwards.
3. Choose one script from Step 2 and change the words so they sound like you.
4. Say it out loud three times, alone. Notice how it feels in your body.
5. Write when you might use it in the coming week.
6. After you use it, write one line about what actually happened.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Neha, 26, always agrees to cover extra shifts at the hospital where she works as an administrator. She is tired and snaps at her younger brother at home, then feels terrible.

After: The next time she is asked, she says, “I can cover Saturday morning, but not the evening.” Her supervisor says, “Okay, I will ask someone else for the evening.” Neha’s heart beats fast for a few minutes afterwards. But on Saturday evening she has dinner with her family, and she notices she feels lighter.

One small step for today: Use one pause sentence before agreeing to anything, even something small.

Reflection question: Where in your life would one small “no” create a little more room for you?

A boundary is not a wall against others. It is a door you are allowed to close.

PART THREE

Everyday Stress and Emotional Overwhelm

The body, sleep, relationships, money, career and family.

08

CHAPTER 8

When Your Body Feels the Stress Too

> You are in the middle of a busy week. You notice that your shoulders are up near your ears. Your jaw is tight. There is a dull ache at the back of your head that has been there since Monday.
>
> Your stomach feels unsettled before every meeting. At night, your legs feel restless.
>
> You did not run a marathon. You mostly sat at a desk. So why does your body feel like it has been through something?

What you might be experiencing

Stress is not only in the mind. Many people notice it in the body too, such as:

- Tight shoulders, neck or jaw.
- Headaches.
- An unsettled stomach or changes in appetite.
- A fast heartbeat or feeling “on edge”.
- Restlessness, or finding it hard to sit still.
- Feeling tired but wired.
- Difficulty falling or staying asleep.

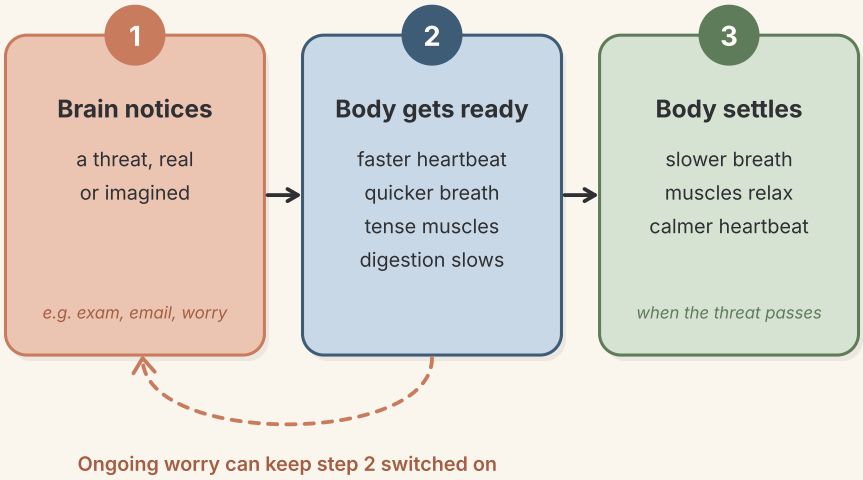
An important note: these experiences can have many causes. Headaches, stomach problems, a racing heart and tiredness can come from stress, but they can also come from dehydration, low iron, thyroid problems, infections, heart conditions, medicine side effects and many

other things. This chapter does not diagnose your symptoms. If you have physical symptoms that are new, severe, lasting or worrying you, please see a doctor. If you have chest pain, difficulty breathing, fainting or sudden severe symptoms, seek emergency medical help immediately.

What may be happening in your body

Your body has a built-in system to help you deal with danger. When your brain notices a threat, it sends signals that prepare your body for action. Your heart may beat faster to move blood to your muscles. Your breathing may speed up. Your muscles tighten, ready to move. Digestion slows down for a while, because it is not a priority during an emergency.

This is often called the **stress response**, or "fight-or-flight". It is a helpful system. It is what makes you jump back from a speeding auto-rickshaw before you have even thought about it.



The stress response is a helpful system that can stay switched on when worry continues.

The difficulty is that the same system can switch on for things that are not physical dangers: an exam, an angry email, a difficult conversation, a worrying thought at night. The body prepares to run, but there is nowhere to run. And if the stress continues day after day, the body may stay a little “switched on” for long periods, which can leave you feeling tense and tired.

The good news is that the body also has a settling system. Slow breathing, gentle movement, rest and feeling safe with others can all help signal to the body that the danger has passed.

The hidden cost

When stress stays in the body for a long time, you might:

- Ignore tension until it becomes pain.
- Feel tired even after sleep.
- Get irritated easily.
- Skip meals, rest or movement because you are “too busy”.
- Worry more about the symptoms themselves, which can add more stress.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Your body is not betraying you. It is trying to protect you in the only way it knows. When your shoulders tighten or your stomach knots, it is like a loyal guard standing at attention for too long. It does not need to be scolded. It needs to be told, gently, that it can stand down for a while.

What can help

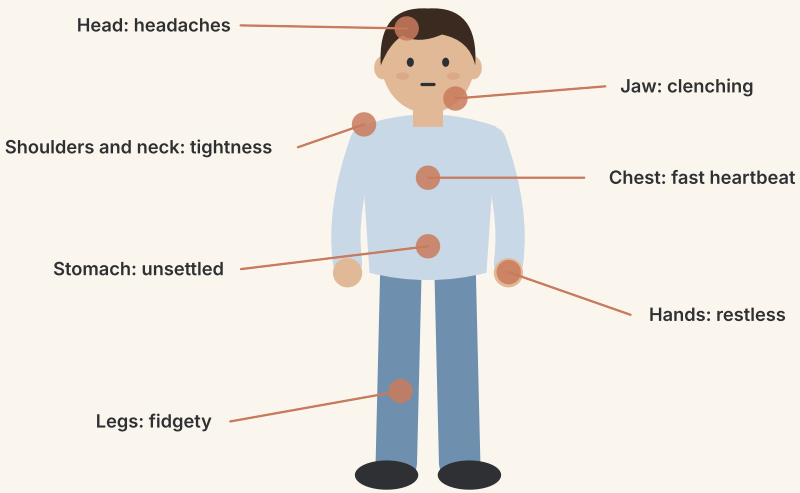
Step 1: Do a quick body check

What: Notice where you are holding tension.

How: Close your eyes or lower your gaze. Slowly move your attention from your head to your feet. Ask: "Where is it tight? Where is it comfortable?" Do not try to fix anything yet. Just notice.

When: Two or three times a day, for example before lunch, after work and before bed.

If it does not help immediately: Some people find body attention uncomfortable at first. If it increases discomfort, open your eyes and focus on something around you instead.



Places stress can show up. These signs can also have other causes.

Stress can show up in the body. These signs can also have other causes, so check with a doctor if you are worried.

Step 2: Release one area at a time

What: Gently tense and relax muscle groups.

How: Pick one area, such as your shoulders. Lift them gently towards your ears for about five seconds, then let them drop and notice the difference for about ten seconds. Try your hands (make a soft fist, then release) and your face (scrunch, then soften). Do not tense hard enough to cause pain. Skip any area that is injured or painful.

When: At your desk, before sleep, or after a stressful conversation.

If it does not help immediately: Relaxation is a skill that improves with practice. Even a small softening counts.

Step 3: Breathe out a little longer

What: Use slow, relaxed breathing to help your body settle.

How: Breathe in gently through your nose for a count of about four. Breathe out slowly, as if through a straw, for a count of about five or six. Do not force your breath or breathe very deeply. Comfort is more important than the exact count. Try for one or two minutes.

When: Before a meeting, after a difficult message, while waiting in a queue.

If it does not help immediately: If focusing on breathing makes you feel dizzy, uncomfortable or more anxious, stop and breathe normally. Some people do better with the grounding exercises in Chapter 13.

Step 4: Move a little

What: Use gentle movement to release tension.

How: A ten-minute walk, stretching your arms above your head, rolling your shoulders, climbing stairs, or dancing to one song in your room. Choose what is comfortable and safe for your body.

When: Especially after long periods of sitting.

If it does not help immediately: Movement often helps more over days and weeks than in a single moment.

Step 5: Look after the basics

What: Support your body with simple care.

How: Drink water regularly, eat at reasonably regular times, take short breaks from screens, and try to keep a regular sleep time. Notice whether too much tea, coffee or energy drinks make you more jittery.

When: Daily. Small changes count.

Exercise: The Three-Minute Body Reset

Time: about 3 minutes

1. Sit comfortably with your feet on the floor.
2. Notice three places in your body that feel tense. Name them silently.
3. Lift your shoulders gently for five seconds, then let them drop.
4. Unclench your jaw. Let your tongue rest softly.
5. Take three slow breaths, letting each out-breath be a little longer than the in-breath.
6. Rate your tension from 0 to 10 before and after. Any small change is worth noticing.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Vikram, a software developer, works for hours without moving. By evening, his neck aches and he feels irritable. He assumes this is just how work is.

After: He sets a reminder every 90 minutes to stand, roll his shoulders and drink water. He also sees a doctor about his frequent headaches, to rule out other causes. The busy weeks are still busy, but he notices tension earlier, and his evenings are a little less tense.

One small step for today: Three times today, drop your shoulders and unclench your jaw.

Reflection question: Where does stress usually show up first in your body?

Your body has been holding on for you. You can let it rest for a moment.

09

CHAPTER 9

Why Is It So Hard to Sleep When I Need Rest?

> You know you need to sleep. You have an early start tomorrow.
>
> You lie down at 11. By 11:30, you are reviewing an argument from three years ago. By midnight, you are calculating: *If I fall asleep now, I will get six hours.* At 12:40: *Five and a half hours. Tomorrow is ruined.*
>
> The more you try to sleep, the more awake you feel. It is like trying to fall asleep while someone keeps shaking your shoulder, except the someone is your own mind.

What you might be experiencing

Many people find that night is when overthinking is strongest. You might notice:

- Replaying the day: conversations, mistakes, things left undone.
- Planning tomorrow in detail.
- Worrying about sleep itself: “What if I cannot sleep again?”
- Using the phone in bed to distract yourself, and staying up even later.
- Sleeping at very different times on weekdays and weekends.

Occasional poor sleep is very common, especially during stressful times. If sleep problems happen most nights for weeks, affect your daily functioning, or come with loud snoring, breathing pauses, or other worrying symptoms, it is worth speaking to a doctor. Persistent sleep difficulties can have many causes, and some are very treatable.

What may be happening in your mind

During the day, your mind is busy with work, people and noise. At night, all of that falls away. The unfinished thoughts that were waiting in the background finally get the stage.

There is also the **pressure** problem. Sleep is one of the few things that gets harder the more you try. Trying hard to sleep keeps your mind alert, like trying hard to forget something. The worry “I must sleep now” can itself keep you awake.

And then there is habit. If your bed has become a place where you scroll, work, eat, argue and worry, your brain may start to link the bed with being alert rather than resting.

The hidden cost

Repeated poor sleep can make the next day harder in many ways:

- Concentration and memory may be weaker.
- Emotions can feel stronger and harder to manage.
- Small problems may feel bigger.
- Tiredness can make it harder to do the things that help, like exercise or seeing friends.

And so the cycle continues.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

If you lie awake at night, you are not doing sleep “wrong”. Many, many people struggle in exactly the same way. Your mind is not your enemy; it simply has not been given another time to think. Tonight, you do not need to sleep perfectly. You only need to give yourself a little more chance to rest.

What can help

These ideas are widely recommended by health services. They do not guarantee sleep, and they will not cure an ongoing sleep disorder. But they give your mind and body a better chance.

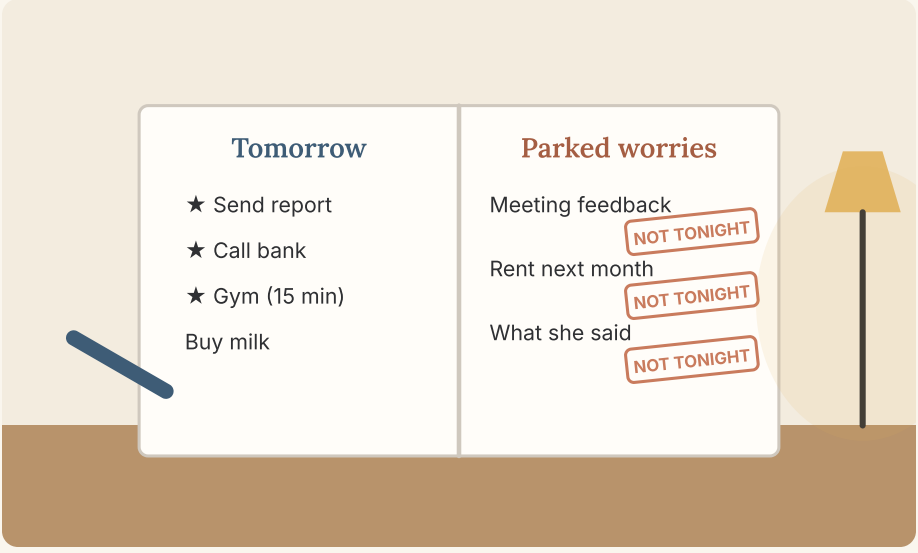
Step 1: Park your thoughts before bed

What: Write down tomorrow's tasks and today's worries before bed.

How: Take a notebook. On one side, write "Things to do tomorrow". On the other, "Things on my mind". Next to each worry, write one small next step, or "Not tonight".

When: About 30 to 60 minutes before bed, not in bed itself.

If it does not help immediately: When a thought appears later, tell yourself, "It is parked in the notebook. I will pick it up tomorrow." Repeat as often as needed.



Parking worries on paper before bed tells the mind they will not be forgotten.

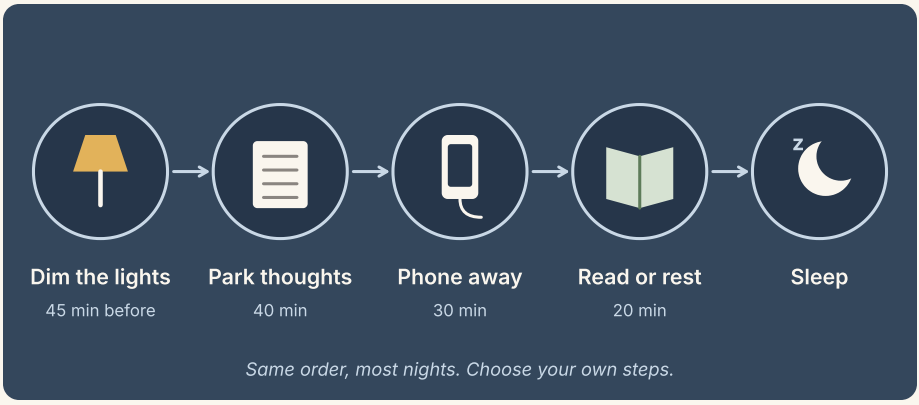
Step 2: Create a short wind-down routine

What: Give your body a signal that the day is ending.

How: Choose three or four calm activities and do them in the same order each night. For example: dim the lights, have a warm shower or wash your face, read a few pages of a paper book, write your thought-parking list, listen to quiet music.

When: Start 30 to 45 minutes before your planned sleep time.

If it does not help immediately: Routines work through repetition. Give it at least two weeks before judging it.



A short routine, in the same order most nights, signals that the day is ending.

Step 3: Put the phone to sleep before you

What: Reduce screens before bed.

How: Charge your phone away from your bed if possible. If you use it as an alarm, keep it face down and out of reach. Set a “phone off” time, say 30 minutes before bed.

If it does not help immediately: The urge to check will be strong at first. Keep a book or notebook where your phone used to be.

Step 4: If you cannot sleep, get up for a while

What: Avoid spending a long time lying awake and frustrated.

How: If you have been awake for what feels like a long time (do not watch the clock), get out of bed and do something quiet and boring in dim light: read something simple, fold clothes, sit by the window. Return to bed when you feel sleepy.

When: Whenever you are lying awake and feeling frustrated.

If it does not help immediately: This can feel hard at first, especially in a shared room or small home. If you cannot get up, sit up in bed with a dim light and a simple book instead.

Step 5: Keep a steady wake-up time

What: Wake at roughly the same time every day, including weekends.

How: Choose a realistic time and keep to it within about an hour, even after a bad night. Get some daylight soon after waking.

If it does not help immediately: A regular wake-up time often helps sleep over several weeks, not one night.

Exercise: The Thought Parking Lot

Time: about 5 minutes, before bed

1. Draw three boxes on a page: **Tomorrow's tasks**, **Worries**, **Good things from today**.
2. In the first box, list tomorrow's tasks. Star the top three.
3. In the second box, write any worry. Next to each, write a next step or "Not tonight".
4. In the third box, write one or two small good things from today, even tiny ones.
5. Close the notebook and put it away from your bed. Say, "Everything is parked. I can rest."

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Shalini, 34, a call-centre team lead, lies awake every night thinking about the next day's targets. She checks her phone until 1 a.m., then wakes up exhausted.

After: She writes her thought-parking list at 10 p.m., keeps her phone on the kitchen shelf, and reads a magazine in bed. Some nights she still struggles, and on those nights she sits by the window for a while. Over three weeks, she notices she falls asleep a little earlier on most nights, and she worries less about the bad ones.

One small step for today: Tonight, write down three things on your mind before you go to bed.

Reflection question: What is one thing in your current bedtime routine that keeps your mind more awake?

Rest is not a reward for finishing everything. It is what helps you face tomorrow.

10

CHAPTER 10

Relationship Worries and Emotional Uncertainty

> Your partner has been quiet all evening. They answered your questions with “hmm” and “okay”. They are looking at their phone a lot.
>
> Your mind starts working. *Did I do something? Are they losing interest? Is there someone else? Should I ask? If I ask, will I seem insecure? If I do not ask, will this get worse?*
>
> You lie next to them, wide awake, while they fall asleep easily.
>
> The next morning, they mention that their team had a terrible day and their manager shouted at everyone. The quietness had nothing to do with you.

What you might be experiencing

Relationships, whether with a partner, family or friends, are some of the most common places for overthinking. You might notice:

- Worrying when someone replies late or in fewer words than usual.
- Reading a lot into tone, silence or small changes in behaviour.
- Fear of rejection or being left out.
- Avoiding disagreements, then thinking about them for days.
- Assuming you know what the other person is thinking or feeling.

When you care about someone, it is natural to want to feel secure with them. The difficulty comes when uncertainty becomes so uncomfortable that your mind fills every gap with a worrying story.

What may be happening in your mind

When we feel unsure about where we stand with someone, the mind becomes alert. It starts scanning for signs, a bit like a detective looking for clues. And just like a detective who is already sure of the answer, it tends to find the clues that fit the fear.

This is sometimes called **mind-reading**: believing you know what someone else is thinking without them telling you. It feels very convincing. But other people's minds are usually busy with their own lives, worries and moods, most of which have nothing to do with us.



Asking gently often replaces hours of guessing.

The hidden cost

Overthinking in relationships can:

- Create arguments about things that did not actually happen.
- Lead to checking behaviour, such as repeatedly asking for reassurance or watching someone's online activity, which can damage trust.
- Make you hold back your real feelings, so the other person never gets a chance to understand you.
- Leave you anxious even in relationships that are actually stable.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Wanting to feel safe and loved is one of the most human needs there is. If you worry about your relationships, it is usually because they matter to you deeply. You do not need to stop caring. You can learn to ask instead of guess.

What can help

Step 1: Check facts before reacting

What: Separate what you saw from what you imagined.

How: Use the two columns from Chapter 2. *Fact:* "He replied with one word." *Story:* "He is angry with me." Then write at least two other possible explanations: tired, busy, distracted, not feeling well, worried about something else.

When: Before sending a reaction, especially a long or emotional message.

If it does not help immediately: Give yourself a small time gap, such as 30 minutes, before responding.

Step 2: Ask simply and directly

What: Replace guessing with a calm, clear question.

How: Use gentle "I" statements instead of accusations. For example:

- “You seem quiet today. Is everything okay?”
- “I noticed we have not talked much this week. I miss our chats. Is something on your mind?”
- “When plans changed last minute, I felt a little hurt. Can we talk about it?”

When: When you are calm enough to listen to the answer, not in the middle of a heated moment.

If it does not help immediately: The other person may not be ready to talk. You can say, “That is okay. I am here when you want to talk,” and give them space.

Step 3: Do not monitor or control

What: Choose trust and conversation over checking.

How: Avoid checking someone’s phone, “last seen” status, location, or social media activity to find reassurance. It may feel like it will calm you, but it usually increases worry and harms trust. If you notice the urge, write it down and come back to Step 2.

If it does not help immediately: If you constantly feel unsafe in a relationship, it may help to talk to a counsellor, either alone or together.

Step 4: Respect your own emotional boundaries

What: Make sure the relationship also respects your needs.

How: Notice if you are always the one adjusting, apologising or waiting. It is okay to say, “I need us to talk this through calmly,” or “I need some time to think before we continue this conversation.”

When: In any relationship where you feel your needs are often ignored.

Important: If someone is threatening, controlling, hurting or frightening you, this is not something you should solve by changing your own thinking. Please reach out to someone you trust, a counsellor, or emergency services (**112**) if you are in danger.

Step 5: Handle disagreements respectfully

What: Treat a disagreement as a problem to solve together, not a battle.

How: Talk about one issue at a time. Describe the situation, how you felt, and what you need. Listen without planning your reply. Take a break if voices rise, and agree to come back to it.

Example: "When I am told about family plans at the last minute, I feel stressed. Could we try to share plans a day earlier?"

Exercise: The Three-Explanation Pause

Time: about 4 minutes

1. Write the situation that is worrying you in one sentence.
2. Write the explanation your mind jumps to first.
3. Write three other possible explanations, even if they seem less likely.
4. Ask: "What would I need to know to be sure?"
5. Write one calm question you could ask the person, using "I" language.
6. Decide: ask now, ask later, or let it go for today.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Ravi, 23, notices his best friend has not replied in the group chat for two days. He assumes he is being left out and sends a sarcastic message: "Guess I am not important anymore."

After: The next time something similar happens, he writes three other explanations, then sends: "Hey, haven't heard from you in a while. All good?" His friend replies that he has been travelling for a cousin's wedding. Ravi still feels worried for a while, but he avoids an argument, and the friendship feels warmer.

One small step for today: The next time you notice yourself mind-reading, write down two other possible explanations.

Reflection question: Is there a conversation you have been avoiding that might actually bring you closer to someone?

A kind question builds more peace than a hundred silent guesses.

11

CHAPTER 11

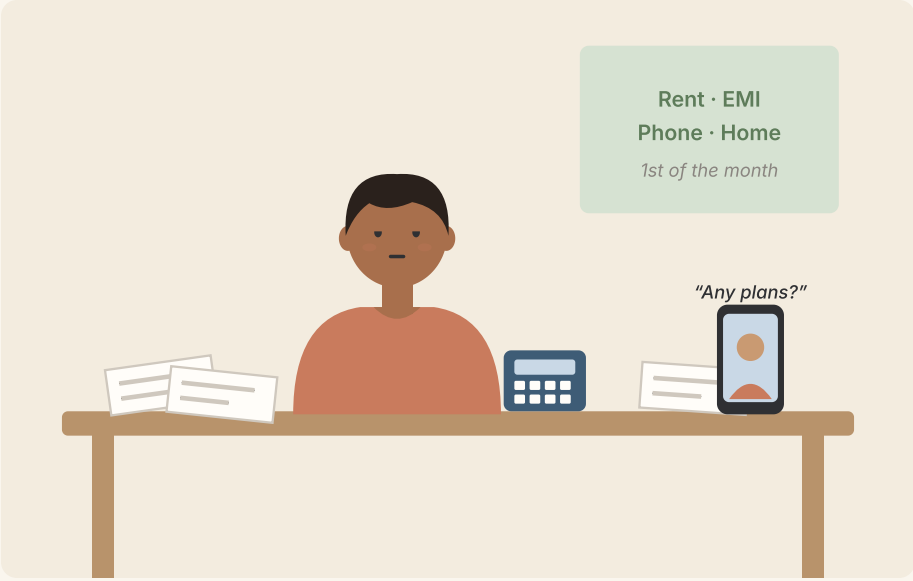
Money, Career and Family Pressure

It is the first of the month. Rent, the phone bill, the education loan EMI and money for home are all due in the same week.

Your salary came in. It is already mostly gone.

On the family call that evening, your mother asks, kindly, if you have thought about buying a flat. Your uncle mentions that his son has just been promoted. You smile and say, “Yes, yes, I am working on it.”

After the call, you sit with your laptop open, looking at job listings you will not apply for, feeling like you are running and still standing in the same place.



Money, career and family pressure often arrive together, at the start of the month.

What you might be experiencing

Money, career and family pressure often arrive together. You might feel:

- Worry about salary, savings, loans or rising expenses.
- Responsibility to support parents or siblings, sometimes from a young age.
- Pressure to choose a "safe" career or a respected one, rather than one you want.
- A sense that you are "behind" in life: no house, no marriage, no promotion yet.
- Guilt for wanting things for yourself.
- Fear of disappointing people who sacrificed for you.

These are not imaginary problems. Financial pressure is real, and so are family responsibilities. Thinking more positively will not pay a bill. But how you approach these pressures can make a real difference to how heavy they feel, and to what you are able to do about them.

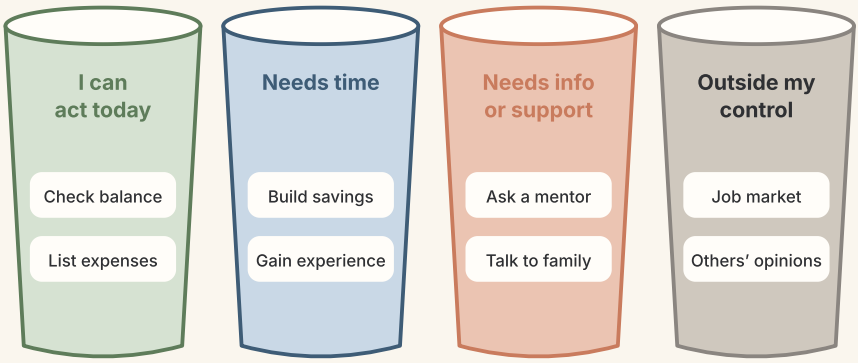
What may be happening in your mind

When a problem is big and has many parts, the mind tends to see it as one huge, frightening cloud: “My finances are a mess.” “My career is going nowhere.” “I will never meet everyone’s expectations.”

A cloud is hard to act on. You cannot push a cloud.

But most big problems can be divided into smaller pieces, and those pieces fall into different groups. Some you can act on today. Some need time. Some need information or help from someone else. And some are outside your control.

My worry, made specific → sorted into four groups



Spend most of your energy on the first column.

Sorting a big worry into four groups shows where your energy is most useful.

Family expectations add another layer. Many families express love through concern and advice. Parents who struggled may want security for their children above all. Understanding *why* someone has an expectation does not mean you must meet it, but it can help you talk about it with less hurt on both sides.

The hidden cost

When these pressures stay as a cloud, you might:

- Avoid looking at your finances at all, because it feels too stressful.
- Make sudden decisions to escape the feeling, such as an impulsive purchase, a risky loan, or quitting without a plan.
- Feel constant guilt, whatever you choose.
- Stay silent with family, so misunderstandings grow.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

If you are carrying financial or family responsibilities, especially at a young age, you are doing something genuinely hard. You are allowed to feel tired of it. You are allowed to want a life of your own while still caring for the people you love. Both things can be true.

What can help

A note: this chapter does not give financial or legal advice. For decisions about loans, investments, insurance or debts, please speak to a qualified, registered professional. Be careful of anyone promising quick or guaranteed returns.

Step 1: Turn the cloud into a list

What: Write down each specific money, career or family worry.

How: One worry per line. Be specific. Not “money problems”, but “I do not know how much I spend on food each month” or “I owe ₹40,000 on my credit card”.

When: Once, in a quiet moment, then review weekly.

If it does not help immediately: Writing it down can feel uncomfortable, especially with money. Go slowly. You can do half the list today.

Step 2: Sort each worry into one of four groups

What: Use the Worry-to-Action Planner (Worksheet 3 at the back of the book).

How: For each worry, decide which column it belongs to:

1. **I can do something today.** (Check my bank balance; list this month's expenses.)
2. **This needs time.** (Building savings; getting experience for a better role.)
3. **This needs information or support.** (Understanding loan options; asking a mentor about career paths; talking to a family member.)
4. **This is outside my control right now.** (The job market; a relative's opinion.)

When: Straight after writing the list.

Step 3: Take one action from the first column

What: Do one small, concrete thing today.

How: Pick the easiest item. Spend 15 to 30 minutes on it.

Example: Kunal opens his banking app and writes down last month's spending in five categories. He feels anxious at first, but now he has numbers instead of fear.

If it does not help immediately: Facts can be uncomfortable. But a clear problem, even a difficult one, is easier to handle than a vague one.

Step 4: Plan a calm family conversation

What: Talk about expectations instead of silently carrying them.

How: Choose a calm time, not during a festival or an argument. Start with care: "I know you want the best for me." Share your situation honestly: "Right now my priority is paying off my loan. Buying a house will take a few more years." Ask about their worries too.

If it does not help immediately: Families do not always change their views after one conversation. You may need several. You can still be respectful while disagreeing.

Step 5: Define "enough" for this stage of life

What: Choose your own markers of progress.

How: Write: "For the next year, I will feel I am doing okay if..." Make the items realistic and within your influence, such as building a small emergency fund, learning one skill, or keeping regular contact with family.

Exercise: Worry to Action

Time: about 10 minutes

1. Write three money, career or family worries.
2. For each, write one sentence that makes it more specific.
3. Place each in a column: **Today / Needs time / Needs information or support / Outside my control**.
4. Circle one item in the "Today" column. Do it, or schedule it for a specific time.
5. For one "Needs information or support" item, write the name of one person or source you could ask.
6. For items outside your control, write: "I will notice this worry and return to what I can do."

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Ayesha, 28, a nurse supporting her parents, feels a knot in her stomach every payday. She avoids looking at her accounts and says yes to every family request, even when she cannot afford it.

After: She spends one Sunday morning listing her expenses and sorting her worries. She speaks to her brother about sharing their parents' medical costs. She still feels pressure, and money is still tight. But she now knows her numbers, has a small plan, and no longer carries every decision alone.

One small step for today: Write down one money, career or family worry, and one small action you could take about it this week.

Reflection question: What does “doing well enough” mean for you at this stage of your life, not someone else’s?

You cannot carry the whole future on your shoulders today. You can carry today’s piece.

PART FOUR

Practical Ways to Feel More in Control

Tools for thoughts, overwhelming moments, decisions, routines and setbacks.

12

CHAPTER 12

How to Stop Feeding Every Thought

> You are cooking dinner. Out of nowhere, a thought appears: *You are going to mess up tomorrow's interview.*
>
> You did not invite it. You were thinking about onions.
>
> But now the thought is here, and you start to argue with it. *No, I prepared well. But what if they ask about the gap year? What if I freeze? I froze once in college…*
>
> Twenty minutes later, the onions are burnt and you are halfway through imagining the rejection email.

What you might be experiencing

Thoughts arrive all day, many of them on their own. Some are useful. Some are random. Some are worried, critical or frightening.

The problem is often not that the thought *appears*. It is what we do next. Many of us:

- Believe a thought simply because it feels strong.
- Argue with it, again and again.
- Try hard to push it away, only for it to come back stronger.
- Act on it immediately, such as cancelling plans, sending an angry message, or checking something repeatedly.

This chapter is about learning a different relationship with your thoughts.

What may be happening in your mind

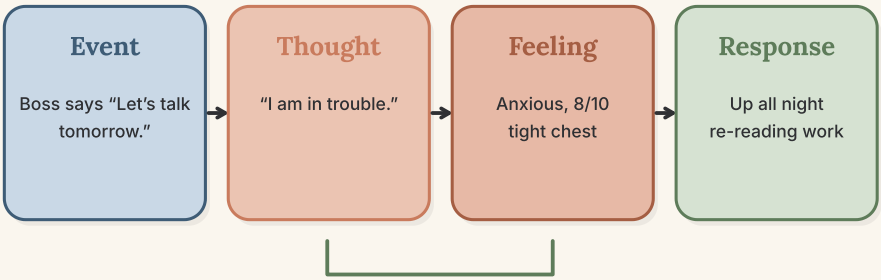
Here is something that surprises many people: **having a thought does not make it true, and it does not mean you have to act on it.**

There are three different steps that we often blend together:

1. **Having a thought:** "I am going to fail." This just shows up.
2. **Believing the thought:** "Yes, I am definitely going to fail."
3. **Acting on the thought:** Not preparing, cancelling the interview, or staying up all night re-reading.

You cannot always control step one. But with practice, you can get more choice over steps two and three.

It also helps to see how a single moment unfolds. Something happens (an **event**). Your mind adds a **thought** about it. The thought shapes a **feeling**. The feeling leads to a **response**. When we understand this chain, we can find places to pause it.



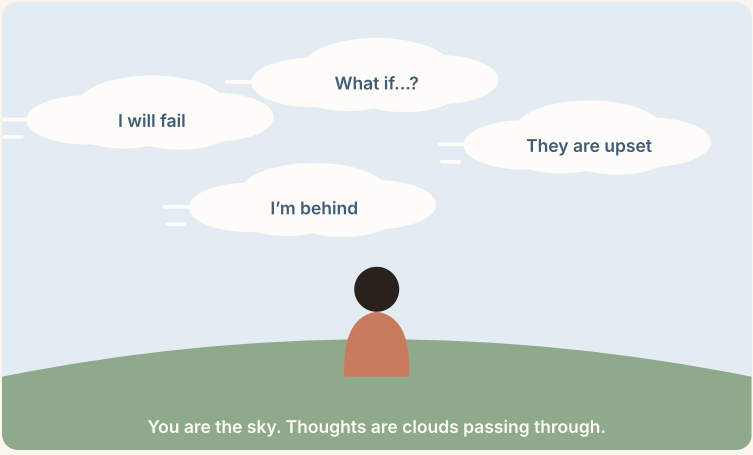
A moment unfolds as event, thought, feeling and response. The pause after the thought is where choice begins.

Think of thoughts as clouds passing across the sky. Some are light, some are dark and heavy. You are not the clouds; you are more like the sky. You do not have to grab each one and examine it.

The hidden cost

When every thought is treated as an emergency or a fact, you might:

- Spend hours arguing with your own mind.
- Make decisions based on fear instead of facts.
- Feel exhausted from constant inner debate.
- Believe harsh things about yourself just because you thought them.



You are the sky. Thoughts are clouds that pass through.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Your mind produces thousands of thoughts. Some will be strange, unkind or frightening. That is not a sign that something is wrong with you. It is what minds do. You are not responsible for every thought that passes through. You are responsible for what you choose to feed.

What can help

Step 1: Label the thought

What: Add a few words before the thought to create distance.

How: Instead of "I am going to fail," say to yourself, "I am having the thought that I am going to fail." Or, more simply, "There is a worry thought."

When: Whenever a thought feels very strong or sticky.

If it does not help immediately: It can feel artificial at first. Try it ten times over a day. Many people find the thought feels a little less like a fact and more like a passing event.

Step 2: Ask three questions

What: Check the thought gently, without arguing for hours.

How: Ask: "Is this thought true for certain? Is it helpful right now? What would I say to a friend who had this thought?"

When: Once per thought. If it returns, label it (Step 1) rather than starting the full debate again.

Step 3: Choose your response

What: Decide what to do based on your values, not only on the thought.

How: Ask: "If I were not having this thought, what would I do right now?" Then try to do that, even with the thought still present.

Example: "If I were not worried about the interview, I would finish cooking, eat with my family, review my notes for twenty minutes and sleep." So you do that, while the worry tags along in the background.

If it does not help immediately: You do not need the thought to leave before you act. You can carry it with you, like a noisy passenger on a bus, while you still drive.

Step 4: Do not try to force thoughts away

What: Let unwanted thoughts be there without fighting them.

How: If you try hard *not* to think about something, it often appears more. Instead, notice the thought, label it, and gently return your attention to what you are doing.

When: Especially with repeating or upsetting thoughts.

Important: If you have distressing thoughts that keep coming back, feel very hard to ignore, or lead you to repeat actions (like checking or washing) to feel okay, please consider speaking to a mental health professional. These patterns are common and treatable, and you do not have to manage them alone.

Exercise: A Simple Thought Record

Time: about 10 minutes

Draw five columns in your notebook:

1. **Event:** What happened? (Facts only.)
2. **Thought:** What went through my mind?
3. **Feeling:** What did I feel, and how strongly (0–10)?
4. **Response:** What did I do, or want to do?
5. **Another view:** Is there a more balanced or kinder way to see this? What could I do instead?

Fill in one row about a recent situation. Then rate your feeling again. Even a one-point change matters.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Ishaan, 21, gets a low mark in an internal test. The thought "I am not cut out for engineering" appears. He believes it completely and skips the next two lectures.

After: The next time, he fills in a thought record. *Event:* "I got 11 out of 30." *Thought:* "I am not cut out for this." *Feeling:* Hopeless, 8/10. *Another view:* "I struggled with this topic. I have passed other tests. I can ask my professor about the mistakes." He still feels disappointed, about 5/10. But he goes to class the next day.

One small step for today: Catch one unhelpful thought today and add “I am having the thought that...” in front of it.

Reflection question: Which thought do you tend to believe most quickly, without checking?

You can hear a thought without obeying it.

13

CHAPTER 13

How to Calm Yourself During an Overwhelming Moment

> You are standing in a crowded market. The noise suddenly feels too loud. Your heart is beating fast. Your thoughts are racing: *I need to get out. Something is wrong. Everyone is looking.*
>
> Or perhaps you have just received difficult news, and you are sitting in the office washroom, trying to steady yourself before you go back to your desk.
>
> Or it is the night before your exam, and the pages in front of you have stopped making sense.
>
> In moments like these, you do not need a long explanation. You need something to hold on to.

What you might be experiencing

An overwhelming moment can feel different for different people. You might notice:

- A rush of strong emotion: fear, anger, sadness, panic.
- A fast heartbeat, fast breathing, shaking or sweating.
- Feeling unreal, far away, or “not here”.
- Racing thoughts, or your mind going blank.
- A strong urge to escape.

These moments are very uncomfortable. They are also usually temporary. Strong emotions rise, reach a peak and gradually come down, like a wave.

Please note: if you experience sudden chest pain, difficulty breathing, fainting, or symptoms you have never had before, seek medical help immediately. Do not assume it is “just stress”. If overwhelming moments or panic-like episodes happen often, a doctor or mental health professional can help.

What may be happening

In an overwhelming moment, your body’s alarm system is switched on strongly. Your attention narrows onto the threat, real or imagined, and your thinking brain finds it harder to work clearly.

That is why trying to “think your way out” in the middle of the wave often does not work. Instead, it can help to **use your senses**: to bring your attention back to the physical world around you, here and now. This is called **grounding**.

Grounding does not make the feeling disappear instantly. It gives your mind something steady to hold while the wave passes.

The hidden cost

When we do not have tools for these moments, we might:

- Avoid places or situations where they happened before.
- Feel afraid of the feeling itself.
- Use quick escapes that do not help in the long run, like endless scrolling, drinking, or snapping at others.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

If you have ever felt overwhelmed in a public place, at work or at home, and thought "What is wrong with me?", you are not alone. These moments are far more common than most people realise. Feeling overwhelmed does not mean you are weak. It means your system was pushed past its limit for a moment, and it is trying to protect you.

What can help

Try the options below and notice which ones suit you. Everyone is different. **If any exercise makes you feel worse, stop and try a different one.**

Option 1: The 5-4-3-2-1 senses exercise

What: Use your senses to return to the present.

How: Slowly notice:

- **5** things you can see.
- **4** things you can touch or feel.
- **3** things you can hear.
- **2** things you can smell (or two smells you like, if you cannot smell anything).
- **1** thing you can taste, or one kind thing you can say to yourself.

When: Anywhere: at your desk, on a bus, in a shop, at home.

If it does not help immediately: Go slowly. If it feels like too much, just do the "5 things you can see" part.

5 · 4 · 3 · 2 · 1



Go slowly. If it feels like too much,
just do the first step: five things you can see.

The 5-4-3-2-1 exercise uses your senses to return to the present.

Option 2: Feel your feet on the floor

What: Use your body's contact with the ground to feel steady.

How: Press your feet gently into the floor. Notice the pressure, the temperature, your shoes or the floor under your feet. If sitting, notice the chair holding your weight. Say silently, "I am here. I am on the ground."

When: If breathing exercises do not suit you, this is a good alternative.

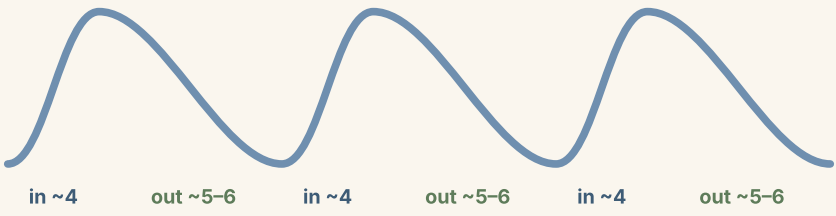
Option 3: Relaxed breathing, gently

What: Let your out-breath slow down.

How: Breathe in softly through your nose for about four counts. Breathe out gently for about five or six counts, as if blowing on hot tea. Do not take very big, deep breaths. Do this for one or two minutes.

When: Once the most intense part of the wave has eased a little, or before a stressful event.

If it does not help immediately: If focusing on breathing makes you feel dizzy, more anxious or short of breath, stop and simply breathe normally. Use Option 1 or 2 instead.



Breathe in gently, and let the out-breath be a little longer.

Comfort matters more than counting. Stop if you feel dizzy.

A gentle rhythm: a short breath in, a slightly longer breath out.

Option 4: Shift your attention with a task

What: Give your mind a simple, absorbing job.

How: Count backwards from 100 in sevens. Name all the colours you can see. Describe the room in detail as if to a friend on the phone. Recite the names of cricket teams, songs you like, or dishes from your home state.

When: When thoughts are racing and you need a break from them.

Option 5: Hold something

What: Use touch to anchor yourself.

How: Hold a cup of warm tea with both hands. Run cool (not ice-cold) water over your hands and notice the feeling. Hold a smooth stone, a key or a soft cloth, and notice its texture and weight.

Option 6: Tell yourself what is happening

What: Name the experience calmly.

How: Say: “This is a wave of strong feeling. It is uncomfortable, but it will pass. I do not have to do anything right now except breathe and stay here.”

Exercise: Build Your Calm Card

Time: about 6 minutes

1. On a small card or in your phone notes, write **“When it feels like too much”**.
2. Choose two or three options from this chapter that you think might suit you.
3. Write each one as a short instruction. *(For example: “Feet on floor. Name 5 things I see.”)*
4. Add one kind sentence you want to hear. *(For example: “This will pass. I can get through the next few minutes.”)*
5. Add the name and number of one person you can contact.
6. Practise one option on a calm day, so it feels familiar when you need it.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Meenal, 30, feels a rush of panic in a crowded bank queue. She leaves without finishing her work and avoids going back for weeks.

After: She makes a calm card and practises the feet-on-the-floor exercise at home. The next time she feels the rush in a queue, she presses her feet down and names five things she can see. Her heart is still racing, but it slows over a few minutes, and she stays. She also books an appointment with her doctor to talk about how often this has been happening.

One small step for today: Try the 5-4-3-2-1 exercise once today, at a calm moment, so it is ready when you need it.

Reflection question: Which sense helps you feel most steady: sight, touch, sound, smell or taste?

A wave can feel enormous and still be a wave. It rises, and it falls.

14

CHAPTER 14

Making Decisions Without Endless Doubt

> You need a new pair of earphones. A simple thing.
>
> You open a shopping app. Then another. You compare twelve models. You read reviews. Then you read the one-star reviews. You watch three video comparisons. You add two to your cart and remove them.
>
> Two hours later, you still have no earphones. You feel tired, a little silly, and somehow anxious, as if a wrong choice would be a disaster.
>
> And this is just earphones. Now imagine choosing a college course, a job offer, or whether to move cities.

What you might be experiencing

For people who overthink, decisions can feel very heavy. You might:

- Spend a long time on small choices, such as what to order or what to wear.
- Ask many people for opinions, and then feel more confused.
- Keep researching after you already have enough information.
- Make a decision and then keep reopening it: “Did I choose right?”
- Avoid deciding at all, and let deadlines or other people decide for you.

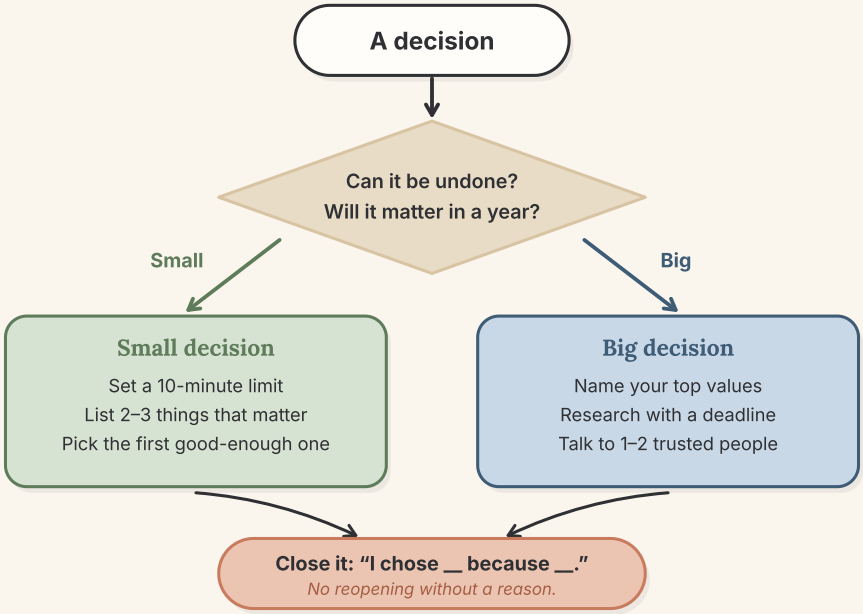
What may be happening in your mind

When the mind fears making a mistake, it tries to find the “perfect” choice, one with no downside. But almost every choice has some downside. So the search never ends.

It also treats all decisions as equally serious. Whether to change careers and which shampoo to buy can trigger the same feeling of pressure.

There is a useful idea from researchers who study decision-making. Some people tend to be **“maximisers”**, always trying to find the very best option, and others are **“satisficers”**, choosing an option that is good enough for their needs. Studies have suggested that people who strongly maximise often feel less satisfied with their choices, even when they choose well, because they keep wondering about the other options.

The key is this: **not every decision deserves the same amount of thinking.**



Not every decision deserves the same amount of thinking.

The hidden cost

Endless decision-making can:

- Waste hours of time and energy.
- Make you feel less confident in your own judgement.
- Cause missed opportunities, because the deadline passes while you are still deciding.
- Keep you stuck in “what if I had chosen the other one?” long after the decision.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

If decisions feel hard for you, it is usually because you want to do the right thing and avoid regret. That is a thoughtful quality. But no amount of research can guarantee a perfect outcome. You are allowed to make a reasonable choice with the information you have, and to adjust if you need to.

What can help

Step 1: Sort the decision by size

What: Ask how much the decision really matters.

How: Ask two questions: **“Can this be undone or changed later?”** and **“Will this matter much in one year?”**

- If it can be changed and will not matter much in a year, it is a **small decision**.
- If it is hard to undo or will matter a lot, it is a **big decision**.

Example: Earphones: small. A job offer in another city: big.

Step 2: For small decisions, set a time limit

What: Give low-risk decisions a short, fixed time.

How: Decide in advance: "I will choose within ten minutes." Pick two or three things that matter most (for earphones: price under ₹2,000, good battery, comfortable). Choose the first option that meets them.

When: For daily choices: food, clothes, small purchases, which movie to watch.

If it does not help immediately: You may feel uneasy after choosing. That feeling usually fades. Notice that the world did not end.

Step 3: For big decisions, use a structured approach

What: Give important decisions the right amount of care, with an end point.

How:

1. Write the decision clearly. ("Should I accept the job in Hyderabad?")
2. List what matters most to you: values, money, family, growth, health.
3. Gather the information you need from a few trusted sources. Set a deadline for research.
4. Write the pros and cons of each option against what matters to you.
5. Talk to one or two people whose judgement you trust, who know you well.
6. Make a choice by your deadline.

When: For education, career, financial, relationship and major life decisions.

If it does not help immediately: Big decisions often still feel uncertain after careful thought. That is normal. Uncertainty does not mean you chose wrong.

Step 4: Close the decision

What: Stop reopening a decision you have already made.

How: After deciding, write: “I chose ___ because ___. I made the best choice I could with what I knew.” If doubt returns, read the sentence and say, “This decision is closed. I will review it on [date] if needed.”

When: Immediately after a decision, especially if you tend to second-guess.

If it does not help immediately: Doubt may visit for a few days. That is just the mind checking. You do not need to restart the research.

Step 5: Limit reassurance and checking

What: Reduce repeated checking and asking.

How: If you notice yourself asking the same question to many people, or re-reading reviews after buying, set a rule: “I will ask one person once,” or “I will not look at other options for one week after buying.”

Exercise: The Decision Sheet

Time: about 10 minutes

1. Write the decision you are facing.
2. Answer: Can it be undone? Will it matter in one year? Mark it **Small** or **Big**.
3. **If small:** Write two or three things that matter most. Set a ten-minute timer. Choose.
4. **If big:** List your top three values. Write the information you still need and your deadline for getting it.
5. Write your choice (or your deadline to choose).
6. Write the closing sentence: “I chose ___ because **. *This decision is closed until*** .”

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Pooja, 25, has two job offers. For three weeks she makes lists, asks fifteen people, and loses sleep. One offer expires while she is still deciding.

After: With a new decision in front of her, whether to start a part-time course, she writes her top values (growth, time with family, cost), sets a one-week deadline, talks to two people who have done the course, and decides. She still has small doubts. But she reads her closing sentence when they appear, and gets on with the course.

One small step for today: Make one small decision today with a two-minute limit, and do not reopen it.

Reflection question: Which recent decision did you keep reopening, and what would it take to close it?

A good-enough choice made today often beats a perfect choice that never comes.

15

CHAPTER 15

Creating a Life That Feels Less Overwhelming

> You have read about morning routines. Wake at 5. Meditate. Journal. Exercise. Drink warm lemon water. Read twenty pages. Plan your day.
>
> You tried it once. It lasted three days. On the fourth day you overslept, and spent the rest of the day feeling like a failure.
>
> Now even the word “routine” makes you feel slightly guilty.

What you might be experiencing

Many people want a life that feels calmer and more manageable. But they often try to change everything at once, using routines designed for someone else’s life. When it does not work, they feel worse.

You might notice:

- Feeling like you never have time for yourself.
- Starting new habits enthusiastically and dropping them quickly.
- Saying yes to more and more, until there is no space left.
- Rest feeling like “wasting time”.
- Comparing your routine with people online who have very different lives.

What may be happening

A routine is meant to be like a walking stick: something that supports you. But when routines are too strict or too ambitious, they become another stone in your bag: one more thing to fail at.

Real life is unpredictable. Exams, family events, illness, festivals, travel, work rush. A routine that only works on perfect days will not work for long.

What helps more is a **gentle structure**: a few small anchors in your day that you can return to, even on messy days.



Not perfect balance every day, just room for each part across a week.

A gentle day makes some room for each part of life across the week.

The hidden cost

When life has no room to breathe:

- Stress builds without a chance to come down.
- Relationships get only your leftover energy.
- You may lose touch with things that once brought you joy.

- Small problems feel bigger because you have no reserve.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

You do not need to become a different person with a perfect schedule. You need a life with a little more space in it. Small, steady changes, kept up imperfectly, often do more good than a dramatic plan that is dropped after a week.

What can help

Step 1: Choose three daily anchors

What: Pick three small habits that support you.

How: Choose one for the morning, one for the middle of the day and one for the evening. Keep them very small.

Example: Morning: drink a glass of water and open the window. Afternoon: a 10-minute walk after lunch. Evening: the thought-parking list from Chapter 9.

If it does not help immediately: Do one anchor if three is too many. Consistency matters more than quantity.

Step 2: Use "if... then" plans

What: Link a new habit to something you already do.

How: Write: "After I [existing habit], I will [new habit]." For example, "After I brush my teeth at night, I will put my phone on the charger outside my room." Research on "implementation intentions", simple if-then plans, suggests they can make it easier to follow through on goals.

When: For any habit you want to make more automatic.

Step 3: Plan for imperfect days

What: Have a smaller version of each habit for difficult days.

How: For each anchor, write a "minimum version". A 10-minute walk becomes "step outside for two minutes". Reading 20 pages becomes "read one page".

If it does not help immediately: On hard days, the minimum version is not a failure. It is the routine bending instead of breaking.

Step 4: Protect small breaks

What: Build short pauses into your day.

How: Every 60 to 90 minutes of work or study, take a short break. Stand, stretch, drink water, look into the distance, or step outside.

Step 5: Reduce one unnecessary demand

What: Take something off your plate.

How: Look at your week. Ask: "What am I doing that I do not need to do, or not this often?" Examples: an extra WhatsApp group you can mute, a commitment you can step back from, a household task that can be shared or simplified.

Step 6: Make room for people and pleasure

What: Include connection and enjoyment, not just productivity.

How: Schedule one thing each week that you enjoy for its own sake: calling a friend, cooking a favourite dish, playing a sport, gardening, music, a walk in a park, time at a place of worship if that is meaningful to you.

If it does not help immediately: If nothing feels enjoyable for a long time, that is worth noticing and discussing with a professional (see Chapter 18).

Exercise: My Gentle Day

Time: about 8 minutes

1. Draw a circle and divide it into six parts: **Rest, Movement, Work or Study, People, Enjoyment, Basic care** (food, water, hygiene).
2. In each part, rate from 0 to 10 how much attention it gets in a typical week.
3. Choose the part with the lowest score.
4. Write one tiny action you could add to it this week.
5. Write its “minimum version” for a bad day.
6. Write when you will start.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: Sameer, 32, works long hours in a bank and spends weekends on chores. He keeps planning to “get healthy” with a full gym routine and diet, but never starts.

After: He picks three anchors: water when he wakes, a 15-minute walk after lunch, and phone away by 10:30 p.m. On busy days, his walk becomes a five-minute stroll around the building. After a month, he is not transformed. But he feels slightly more energetic, and he has kept going, which has never happened before.

One small step for today: Choose one daily anchor, and decide its minimum version for difficult days.

Reflection question: What is one thing you could remove from your week to create a little breathing room?

Build a life you can return to, not a routine you have to survive.

16

CHAPTER 16

What to Do When You Have a Difficult Day Again

> For two weeks, things have been better. You have been sleeping a little more. You used your thought-parking list. You said no to an extra project. You felt lighter.
>
> Then, on Thursday, everything goes wrong. A harsh comment from your boss. A fight at home. A bad night's sleep. By Friday evening, you are back in the old loop: replaying, worrying, scrolling until 2 a.m.
>
> And a new thought arrives, heavier than the others: *See? Nothing has changed. I am back to square one.*

What you might be experiencing

Difficult days return. For everyone. After a period of feeling better, a setback can feel especially disappointing. You might think:

- "All my effort was useless."
- "I will never really change."
- "Other people improve. I always fall back."
- "Why bother trying?"

These thoughts are understandable. They are also, almost always, not accurate.

What may be happening

Emotional progress does not move in a straight line. It is more like a hill path: some stretches climb, some dip, but over time you still move forward. A bad day is a dip, not the end of the path.



Progress is not a straight line. A hard day is a dip, not the end of the path.

A setback can also be useful information. It may show you a trigger you had not noticed, a habit that needs support, or a moment when you need more help than before.

And there is something important you may miss: **you are probably recovering faster than before.** In the past, a bad day might have turned into a bad month. Now perhaps it is a bad weekend. That is progress, even if it does not feel like it.

The hidden cost

When we treat a difficult day as proof of failure, we may:

- Stop using the tools that were helping.
- Criticise ourselves harshly, which adds more stress.
- Avoid reaching out, because we feel ashamed.

- Turn one bad day into many.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

A difficult day does not erase what you have learned. The skills you practised are still with you, even if you could not use them today. You have not gone back to the beginning. You are standing on a path you have already walked, and you know a little more about it now.

A simple setback plan

When a difficult day comes, use these five steps. You can write them on a card and keep it in your wallet or phone.

Step 1: Notice

What: Recognise what is happening, without judgement.

How: Say, "This is a hard day. I am in a dip." Name what you are feeling: tired, anxious, sad, angry, overwhelmed.

When: As soon as you notice the old pattern returning.

Step 2: Pause

What: Stop before making things worse.

How: Take a short break from whatever is intensifying the feeling: step away from the phone, the argument or the work. Use one grounding tool from Chapter 13.

If it does not help immediately: You do not need to feel better to pause. A pause just stops the slide from speeding up.

Step 3: Identify the need

What: Ask what you need most right now.

How: Ask: "Am I hungry, tired, lonely, overloaded, worried about something specific, or in need of comfort?" Often the need is simple: food, rest, a conversation, fewer demands.

Step 4: Choose one manageable action

What: Do one small thing that meets the need.

How: Pick the smallest helpful action. Eat a proper meal. Go to bed earlier. Message a friend. Write a thought-parking list. Plan only the minimum version of your routine for tomorrow.

Example: After her difficult Thursday, Kavya just eats dinner, takes a shower, and goes to bed without her phone. That is her one action.

Step 5: Seek support if needed

What: Reach out if the dip feels too deep or lasts too long.

How: Talk to someone you trust. If difficult days are becoming more frequent, more intense, or lasting for weeks, consider speaking to a doctor or mental health professional (see Chapter 18).

Important: If on a difficult day you have thoughts of harming yourself or feel you cannot keep yourself safe, please reach out immediately: call **112** for emergencies or **14416** (Tele-MANAS, free, 24/7), or go to the nearest hospital emergency department.

Exercise: Write Your Setback Card

Time: about 7 minutes

1. Write at the top: **“On a hard day, I will…”**
2. **Notice:** Write one sentence you will say to yourself. (“This is a dip, not the end.”)
3. **Pause:** Write one way you will pause. (“Phone in the other room for 30 minutes.”)
4. **Need:** List your most common needs on hard days.
5. **Action:** Write three small actions you can choose from.
6. **Support:** Write the names and numbers of two people you can contact, and one professional or helpline number.
7. Keep the card somewhere easy to find.

BEFORE AND AFTER

Before: After months of feeling better, Arvind has a terrible week at work. He decides his progress was “fake”, stops his evening walks, and does not tell anyone how he feels. The low feeling lasts most of a month.

After: The next time a bad week arrives, he reads his setback card. He tells his sister he is having a hard week. He keeps only his minimum routine: a five-minute walk and phone away at night. The week is still hard. But by the following Monday, he feels steadier, and he notices that he has recovered faster than before.

One small step for today: Write the five setback steps on a card or in your phone notes.

Reflection question: What would you say to a friend who felt they were “back to square one”?

A step back is still a step on the path.

PART FIVE

Your Personal Reset Plan

Seven gentle days,
and knowing when to ask for more support.

17

CHAPTER 17

A 7-Day Mind Reset

You have read about many ideas in this book. Now it is time to bring a few of them together, gently.

This seven-day plan is not a test. It is an invitation to try one thing each day and notice what helps. Most days take between 10 and 25 minutes. Day 6 uses part of your usual evening.

Some guidelines:

- **Start any day of the week.** You do not need to wait for Monday.
- **Missing a day is not failure.** If you miss a day, just continue with the next one. If you need to, repeat a day.
- **Go slowly.** You can stretch the plan over two weeks if that suits you better.
- **Write things down.** Use a notebook, or the 7-Day Progress Reflection worksheet at the back.



Seven small days, one step at a time.

Day 1: Notice your recurring thoughts

Why: You cannot change a pattern you have not noticed. Today is only about observing.

Main activity: Three times today, stop for one minute and ask, “What has my mind been busy with?” Write a few words each time.

Journal prompt: At the end of the day, look at your notes. Which thought or worry appeared more than once? When did it appear? What were you doing at the time?

Time needed: About 10 minutes in total.

Gentle reminder: You are not trying to stop any thoughts today. Just notice them, the way you might notice clouds.

Day 2: Separate facts from assumptions

Why: Many worries feel heavy because guesses feel like facts.

Main activity: Choose one recurring worry from Day 1. Use the Facts vs. Assumptions worksheet. Write at least three facts and three assumptions, and one other possible explanation for each assumption.

Journal prompt: What changed, if anything, when I saw the facts and guesses separately?

Time needed: About 10–15 minutes.

Gentle reminder: You may still believe some assumptions. That is okay. You are practising, not proving.

Day 3: Complete one small task you have been avoiding

Why: Avoided tasks quietly sit in the mind and drain energy. Finishing one small one can bring a sense of relief and momentum.

Main activity: Choose one avoided task. Break it into steps (Chapter 3). Do only the first step, or the whole task if it is small.

Journal prompt: How did I feel before starting? How did I feel after? What made it easier or harder?

Time needed: About 15–25 minutes.

Gentle reminder: If you only manage the first step, that is a success for today.

Day 4: Practise one grounding or relaxation exercise

Why: Calming skills work best when you practise them on calm days, so they are ready on hard ones.

Main activity: Choose one: 5-4-3-2-1 senses, feet on the floor, relaxed breathing, or the three-minute body reset. Practise it twice today, once in the morning and once in the evening.

Journal prompt: Which exercise did I try? How did my body feel before and after (0–10)? Would I use it again?

Time needed: About 10 minutes in total.

Gentle reminder: If an exercise feels uncomfortable, stop and try another. There is no “correct” one.

Day 5: Set one healthy boundary or communicate one need

Why: Small boundaries protect your energy and teach you that your needs matter too.

Main activity: Choose one small situation. Use a pause sentence or a boundary script from Chapter 7, or express one need clearly to someone: “I need some quiet time after work,” or “Can you let me know about plans a day earlier?”

Journal prompt: What did I say? How did it feel? What actually happened?

Time needed: About 10 minutes to prepare, plus the conversation.

Gentle reminder: If today is not the right day for a conversation, write the script and practise it out loud. That counts.

Day 6: Build a gentle evening routine

Why: A calm end to the day can make rest a little easier.

Main activity: Use the Evening Wind-Down Checklist. Choose three or four steps. Try them tonight, in the same order, starting 30–45 minutes before sleep.

Journal prompt: Which steps felt good? Which would I change? What is one thing I will keep doing?

Time needed: About 30–45 minutes in the evening, which replaces some screen time rather than adding to your day.

Gentle reminder: One evening will not fix sleep. You are planting a habit.

Day 7: Reflect on what helped

Why: Not everything will suit you. Today you choose what to keep.

Main activity: Look back at your notes from Days 1–6. Fill in the 7-Day Progress Reflection worksheet.

Journal prompt:

- Which day or tool helped me most?
- Which felt hardest, and why?
- Which two habits do I want to continue next week?
- What support might I need to keep going?

Time needed: About 15–20 minutes.

Gentle reminder: Whatever you managed this week, even one day, is worth acknowledging. You showed up for yourself.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

If you finished this week feeling only a little different, that is completely normal. Small changes are often invisible at first. Like water dripping on a stone, they shape things slowly. You can repeat this plan as many times as you like.

One small step for today: Decide which day you will begin the 7-Day Mind Reset, and write it in your calendar.

Reflection question: What would make it easier for you to keep going on the days you do not feel like it?

Seven small days can open one new door.

18

CHAPTER 18

When You Need More Than a Self-Help Book

> You have tried the brain dumps, the breathing, the thought records. Some things helped a little. But for months now, the heaviness has not really lifted.
>
> You are tired almost all the time. You find it hard to enjoy anything. Work or studies feel like climbing a mountain every day. You have thought about talking to someone, but a voice in your head says, *Others have it worse. You should be able to handle this. What will people think?*
>
> So you keep going, alone, a little more worn down each week.

Self-help has limits, and that is okay

This book can help with everyday stress and overthinking. But a book cannot listen to you, ask questions, understand your full story, or adjust its advice to your life. Sometimes, what you are experiencing needs more than a book can give.

Seeking professional help is not a sign of failure. It is not a sign that you are “crazy”, weak or ungrateful. It is the same as seeing a doctor for a fever that will not go away. You would not tell yourself to “just think positively” about a broken arm.

When it may be time to seek more support

Please consider speaking to a doctor or qualified mental health professional if:

- Your worry, sadness, stress or low mood **has lasted for several weeks** and is not easing.
- It is **getting worse** over time.
- It is making it **hard to manage daily life**: studies, work, relationships, looking after yourself or your home.
- You are having **sleep problems** most nights for weeks.
- You have **panic-like episodes**, sudden intense waves of fear with physical symptoms, especially if they happen repeatedly.
- You **no longer enjoy** things you used to enjoy, or feel numb or hopeless.
- You are **avoiding** many situations because of fear or worry.
- You have **repetitive thoughts or urges** that are very hard to control.
- You are **using alcohol, drugs, or other habits** to cope, and finding it hard to stop.
- Friends or family have told you they are worried about you.

You do not need to wait until things are “bad enough”. If you are struggling and want support, that is reason enough.

If you are in immediate danger, or having thoughts of ending your life or harming yourself:

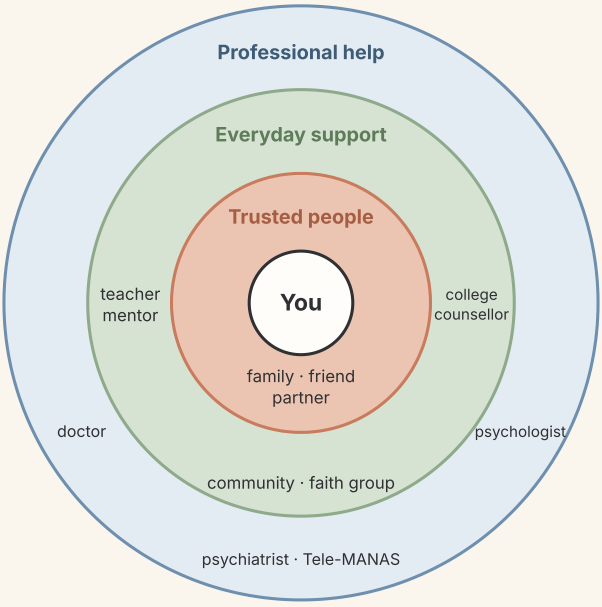
- Call **112** (India's national emergency number), or
- Go to the **nearest hospital emergency department**, or
- Call **Tele-MANAS on 14416** or **1-800-891-4416** (free, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week), and
- Tell someone near you right now: a family member, friend, neighbour, or anyone you trust. Do not stay alone.

You deserve help, and help is available.

Who can help?

Different professionals offer different kinds of support. You do not need to know exactly who to see. Any one of them can guide you.

- **A general doctor (GP or family physician):** a good first step. They can check for physical causes, offer initial support and refer you onwards.
- **A psychiatrist:** a medical doctor who specialises in mental health. They can assess, diagnose and, if needed, prescribe medicine.
- **A clinical psychologist:** trained in assessment and talking therapies. In India, look for registration with the Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI).
- **A counsellor:** can offer support for stress, relationships, adjustment and everyday difficulties. Many colleges and workplaces have counsellors.
- **Government services:** many district hospitals and medical colleges have psychiatry departments. Tele-MANAS can guide you to services near you.



Tele-MANAS 14416 · Emergency 112

Support comes in circles: trusted people, everyday support and professional help.

How to prepare for a first appointment

A first appointment can feel nerve-wracking. Preparing a little can help.

Before you go, write down:

1. What you have been feeling and experiencing, in your own words.
2. When it started and whether anything was happening in your life at that time.
3. How it affects your daily life: sleep, appetite, energy, studies, work, relationships.
4. Any physical health problems and medicines you take, including supplements.
5. Anything you have tried that helped, or did not help.
6. Questions you want to ask. For example: “What do you think might be going on?” “What are my options?” “How long might it take to feel

better?" "What should I do if things get worse?"

During the appointment: It is okay to bring your notes and read from them. It is okay to say, "I do not know how to explain this." It is okay to take someone you trust with you. It is okay to ask the professional to explain anything you do not understand.

After the appointment: If you did not feel comfortable with the person, it is okay to try someone else. Finding the right fit sometimes takes more than one try.

How to talk to someone you trust

Sometimes the first step is telling one person. Choose someone who is usually kind and calm, not necessarily the closest person.

You might say:

- "I have not been feeling like myself lately. Can I talk to you about it?"
- "I am going through a hard time and I do not want to keep it to myself anymore."
- "I do not need you to fix anything. I just need someone to listen."
- "I am thinking of seeing a counsellor. Can you help me find one, or come with me?"

If the first person does not respond well, please do not give up. Their response says more about their understanding than about your worth. Try someone else, or reach out to a helpline.

Support resources in India

The following services were checked against official or service-run sources in October 2026. Contact details and timings can change, so please confirm on the official website before relying on them.

Tele-MANAS (National Tele Mental Health Programme, Government of India)
Call **14416** or **1-800-891-4416** — free, 24×7, in multiple Indian languages. Counselling, support and referral to services near you. Website: telemanas.mohfw.gov.in. The Tele-MANAS mobile app is also available.

Emergency Response Support System
Call **112** for any emergency: police, fire or ambulance, anywhere in India. Website: 112.gov.in.

iCall (psychosocial helpline, Tata Institute of Social Sciences)
Call **9152987821**. Phone counselling by trained professionals, Monday to Saturday, 8 am to 9 pm (as listed in October 2026). Email: icall@tiss.ac.in. Check current hours at icallhelpline.org, which also lists mental health professionals.

Your nearest government or private hospital
Most district hospitals and medical colleges have psychiatry outpatient departments. Hospital emergency departments are open 24 hours.

For readers outside India: Please contact your local emergency number or national mental health helpline.

A MOMENT OF UNDERSTANDING

Asking for help is not giving up. It is deciding that you matter enough to get support. Every person who has ever felt better with help first had to take the same difficult step you are thinking about now.

One small step for today: Save **14416** in your phone, even if you do not need it right now. You might need it someday, or someone you love might.

Reflection question: Who is one person you could talk to if things became harder?

Reaching out is not the end of being strong. It is a different kind of strength.

A CLOSING LETTER

You Do Not Have to Figure Everything Out Today

Dear reader,

We have come a long way together.

We have talked about the mind that will not switch off at night, the messages read again and again, the heavy bag of small tasks, the fear of the future and the fear of not being enough. We have talked about comparison, other people's opinions, the body holding stress, sleep that will not come, relationships, money and family. And we have gathered some tools: brain dumps, fact-checking, boundaries, grounding, thought records, decision limits, gentle routines and setback plans.

Now I want to leave you with something simple.

The goal was never to stop every unwanted thought. Minds produce thoughts. Some of them will always be worried, critical or strange. That is not a problem to be solved. It is part of being human.

The goal was never to control every feeling. You will still feel anxious before important things. You will still feel sad when things are sad. You will still have days when everything feels too much. These feelings are not signs that you have failed.

The goal was never to become happy all the time. Nobody is. The people who seem to be are just showing you their highlight reel.

The real goal is quieter, and more possible:

- To notice your thoughts a little earlier, before they carry you too far.
- To respond to them with a little more kindness and a little less fear.

- To take one small, useful action more often than before.
- To make room for rest, without having to earn it first.
- To ask for support when you need it, without shame.

If this book has helped you do even one of these things, even once, that matters.



You do not have to figure everything out today.

You will forget some of what you read here. That is fine. Come back to it. Open any chapter on a difficult day and find one thing to try. Use the worksheets. Share what helped with someone else who might need it.

And on the days when nothing seems to help, please remember: you do not have to figure everything out today. You do not have to solve your whole life before you are allowed to breathe. You only have to get through this moment, then the next one, gently.

Your mind has been working so hard for you, for so long. It deserves a break, and so do you. Put the heavy things down for a while. They will still be there tomorrow, and you will be a little more rested when you pick them up. You are allowed to rest. You are allowed to be unfinished. You are allowed to begin again, as many times as you need.

With warmth,

Ratnesh Ranve

BONUS

Ten Printable Worksheets

Print these pages, copy them into a notebook,
or fill them in on a tablet.
Use them as often as you like.

WORKSHEET 1

My Overthinking Pattern Tracker

For one week, note the thoughts that keep coming back. Patterns become easier to change once you can see them.

Day	The thought or worry	When / where	Strength 0–10	What I did
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

The thought that visited most often:

A name for this loop:

WORKSHEET 2

Facts vs. Assumptions

A fact is something a camera could record. An assumption is your mind's explanation.

The situation, in one sentence:

Facts (what actually happened)	Assumptions (what my mind is adding)

Other possible explanations for my assumptions:

Is there one useful action? (or "No action needed right now")

WORKSHEET 3

My Worry-to-Action Planner

Turn a cloud of worry into pieces you can work with.

My worry, made specific:

I can do something today

This needs time

Needs information or support

Outside my control right now

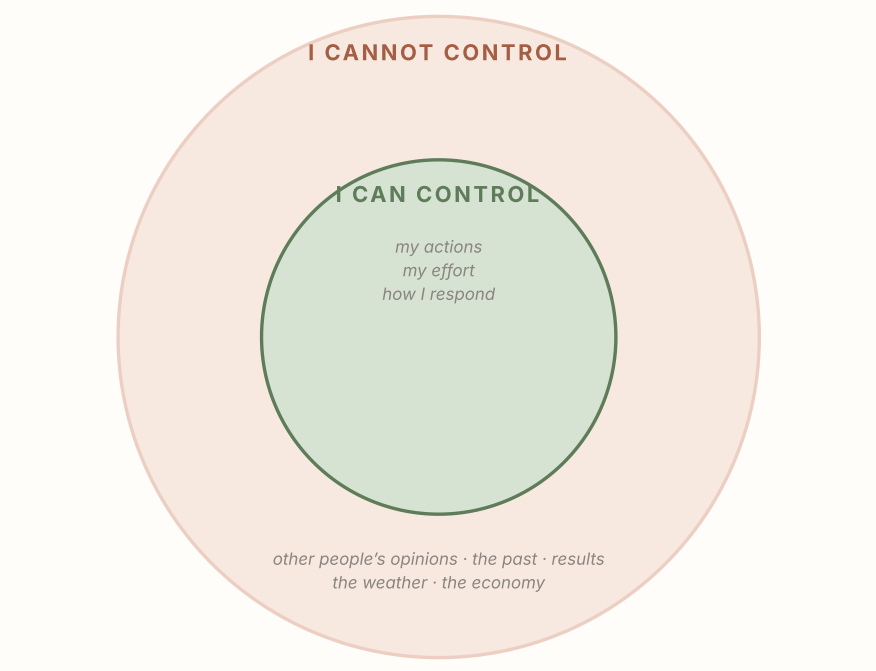
The one action I will take, and when:

Person or source I can ask:

WORKSHEET 4

The Things I Can and Cannot Control

Write the things on your mind in the circle where they belong. Spend your energy on the inner circle.



One thing from the inner circle I will act on this week:

One thing from the outer circle I will practise letting be:

WORKSHEET 5

A Simple Daily Check-In

Two minutes, once a day. Copy this page or answer in your notes app.

Date	
My mood today (0–10)	0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10
My energy (0–10)	0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10
Sleep last night	☐ Good ☐ Okay ☐ Poor
What is on my mind	
What I need today	☐ Rest ☐ Food ☐ Movement ☐ People ☐ Quiet ☐ Help
One small thing I will do for myself	
One thing that went okay	

WORKSHEET 6

My Evening Wind-Down Checklist

Choose three or four steps. Do them in the same order, starting 30–45 minutes before sleep.

☐ Dim the lights in my room

☐ Write tomorrow's top three tasks

☐ Park my worries on paper ("Not tonight")

☐ Phone on charge, away from my bed

☐ Wash my face or take a warm shower

☐ Change into comfortable clothes

☐ Read a few pages of a paper book

☐ Quiet music or a calm prayer, if that suits me

☐ Gentle stretch or three-minute body reset

☐ Write one good thing from today

☐ My own idea: _____

My routine, in order:

1. _____ 2. _____

3. _____ 4. _____

Start time:

WORKSHEET 7

A Boundary-Setting Script Sheet

Pick a script, change the words so they sound like you, and practise out loud.

Pause	"Let me check and get back to you by this evening."
Simple no	"I am not able to do that this time."
No with care	"I really want to help, but I cannot take this on today."
Partial yes	"I cannot do all of it, but I can do this part."
Delayed yes	"I can help on Thursday, not today."
At work	"If I take this on, the other report will be late. Which should I prioritise?"
Expressing a need	"I need some quiet time after work. Can we talk after dinner?"

A situation where I want to set a boundary:

My script, in my own words:

What actually happened when I used it:

WORKSHEET 8

My Personal Support Plan

Fill this in on a calm day, so it is ready on a hard one.

Early signs that I am struggling:

Things that usually help me (from this book or my own life):

People I can talk to (name and number):

My doctor, counsellor or clinic (name and number):

Places where I feel calmer:

Tele-MANAS (free, 24×7): **14416** or **1-800-891-4416** · Emergency: **112**

WORKSHEET 9

My 7-Day Progress Reflection

Use this with the 7-Day Mind Reset in Chapter 17.

Day	Activity	Done?	What I noticed
1	Notice recurring thoughts	☐	
2	Facts vs. assumptions	☐	
3	One avoided task	☐	
4	Grounding or relaxation	☐	
5	One boundary or need	☐	
6	Evening routine	☐	
7	Reflect	☐	

What helped most:

Two habits I will continue next week:

WORKSHEET 10

Emergency and Professional Support Reminder

Keep this page somewhere easy to find. Share it with someone you trust.

If you are in immediate danger or thinking of harming yourself:
Call **112** · Go to the nearest hospital emergency department · Call Tele-MANAS on **14416** · Tell someone near you now.

Emergency (police, fire, ambulance)	**112**
Tele-MANAS, free, 24×7, many languages	**14416** / **1-800-891-4416**
iCall (TISS) psychosocial helpline	**9152987821** (Mon–Sat, 8 am–9 pm)
My doctor or counsellor	
Nearest hospital	
Trusted person 1	
Trusted person 2	

Numbers checked October 2026. Please confirm on official websites, as details can change.

References and Further Reading

This book is written in plain language and does not cite a source for every sentence. The ideas it draws on are well established in public health guidance and psychological research. The sources below are genuine, publicly available, and a good place to read further.

Public health guidance

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All examples and characters in this book are invented for illustration. They are not real people, case studies or testimonials. Links were checked in October 2026.

About the Author

Ratnesh Ranve is a writer based in India who publishes under the OpenPage imprint, creating simple, practical books for everyday life. He wrote *Your Mind Needs a Break* for people who carry too much in their heads: students, young professionals and anyone facing quiet, daily pressure, who want clear and kind guidance they can use straight away.

This book is not offered as clinical advice. Its ideas draw on public health guidance and published research, listed in the references, and it encourages readers to seek professional support whenever they need it.

If this book helped you, even a little,
think of one person who might need it too,
and pass it on.

A Final Reflection

Take a few quiet minutes with these questions. There are no right answers.

What is one thing I understand about my mind now that I did not understand before?

Which tool or idea from this book helped me most?

What is one small habit I want to keep?

What will I say to myself on my next difficult day?

Who is one person I can turn to for support?

✦ ✦ ✦

For the mind that is always on, even when you are trying to rest.

You replay conversations. You read too much into a late reply. You lie awake planning, worrying, wondering if you are falling behind. You are tired, even on days when you have not done much.

Your Mind Needs a Break is a warm, simple and practical guide for students, young professionals and anyone carrying too much in their head. It explains what may be happening in plain words, and then gives you small, realistic steps to try today.

Inside, you will learn how to:

- Recognise overthinking loops and separate facts from assumptions
- Break overwhelming tasks into manageable steps
- Handle worry about the future, failure and comparison
- Set kind, clear boundaries, with ready-to-use scripts
- Calm yourself in overwhelming moments and wind down at night
- Make decisions without endless doubt, and recover from hard days
- Know when, and how, to seek professional support

Includes a 7-Day Mind Reset, 30 original illustrations, and 10 printable worksheets.

You do not have to figure everything out today.

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Self-help / Emotional well-being